

Utah Trip 2026 — Working Copy

Phoenix loop · July 23 – August 16, 2026

Printed from the trip wiki · state as of July 5, 2026

Includes the current fire reroutes (Babylon & Pocket fires),
the day-by-day schedule, permits, and outstanding reservations.

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Action Items — Before the Flight

Summary: Outstanding reservations, confirmations, and checks to complete before departure on July 23, 2026, plus decisions deliberately left for the road.

Sources: Compiled from **schedule**, **permits**, **babylon-fire**, **pocket-fire** (as of 2026-07-05).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Must do before July 23

#	Item	Night / date	Notes
1	Book Tucson motel + note its street address	23/24. 7.	Presumably a Wyndham property near Costco. The address is required for U.S. arrival paperwork — Gilbert Ray CG is closed and BLM sites have no valid registration
2	Christopher Creek CG (Tonto NF, near Payson)	24/25. 7.	Book ahead if reservable; fallback is dispersed camping on Mogollon Rim Road (FR-300)
3	Verde Canyon Railroad tickets	13. 8., 13:00	Book in advance — but first check operating status re pocket-fire and ask about the refund/rebooking policy if smoke worsens
4	Print permit confirmations	—	Coyote Buttes South 30. 7.; White Rim Road 10.–11. 8. Both confirmed — carry paper copies
5	Decide the orange-cliffs-loop	~4–8. 8.	If taking it: verify permit rules with Hans Flat Ranger Station and book the Orange Cliffs campsite (Happy Canyon / Land's End) before it fills
6	Verify existing bookings & print confirmations	—	Coral Pink Sand Dunes CG (27/28), Kodachrome Basin SP (28/29), Goblin Valley SP (3/4), Dead Horse Point SP x2 (8–10. 8.), Monument Valley (12/13), Twin Peaks CG Organ Pipe (14/15), Hilton Phoenix Airport (15/16) — all marked confirmed in schedule ; make sure confirmations are in hand

Fire checks (shortly before and during the trip)

Check	When	Where
babylon-fire status, closure boundary	week before + en route	InciWeb, BLM Monticello, Manti-La Sal NF alerts
Is newspaper-rock / UT-211 open?	before Aug 11	BLM Monticello
Is Comb Wash CG outside the closure?	before Aug 11	BLM Monticello (Nizhoni CG is confirmed closed)
Smoke/AQ forecast for White Rim / White Crack	Aug 9–10	fire.airnow.gov or similar
pocket-fire status; SR-89A closure; railroad running?	before Aug 13	Verde Canyon RR directly; Coconino NF; ein.az.gov
henry-mountains — any new fires? fire restrictions / campfire ban	before Aug 5	BLM Utah fire news

Deliberately unresolved (decide on the road — no booking possible)

- **31. 7.–1. 8.** — Alstrom Point (BLM dispersed, first-come)
- **1–2. 8.** — Smokey Mountain Road area or Escalante

- **2-3. 8.** — Capitol Reef / Boulder area (Upper Muley Twist day)
- **4-5. 8.** — Moonscape Overlook (BLM dispersed)
- **11-12. 8.** — Comb Wash CG (first-come BLM; pending closure check)
- **13-14. 8.** — Surprise designated camping or Blackhawk Loop CG
- **12. 8. on the spot** — **muley-point** climb: go/no-go from Valley of the Gods per cloud/smoke over Cedar Mesa

Related pages

- **[schedule](#)**
- **[permits](#)**
- **[babylon-fire](#)**
- **[pocket-fire](#)**

Trip Schedule — Day by Day

Summary: Full calendar for the Utah loop, July 23 – August 16, 2026. Open items: exact Tucson motel + address for night 0/1; **babylon-fire** reroute details for Aug 11-13; **pocket-fire** — is the Aug 13 train ride viable?

Sources: raw/Časový rozvrh (user schedule, 2026-05-20/21 — see **casovy-rozvrh**); KMZ route files in raw/; user update 2026-07-05 (first-night change, Orange Cliffs loop option).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Conventions

- ✓ Confirmed campground
- ? Not yet decided / needs booking
- ⚠ Permit day — no flexibility on date
- 🛖 Gap — overnight not specified, needs a plan

Full calendar

Night	Date	Day	Segment	Campground	Key activity
0/1	23–24. 7.	Čt	1	? Motel Tucson — presumably a Wyndham property near Costco; exact address TBD	Arrive PHX 19:00; drive to Tucson in the dark. Gilbert Ray CG closed (source: user update 2026-07-05)
1/2	24–25. 7.	Pá	1	✓ Christopher Creek CG (Tonto NF, near Payson)	apache-trail , Roosevelt Dam, mogollon-rim
2/3	25–26. 7.	So	1	✓ Coal Mine Canyon (rim)	meteor-crater ; sunset-crater & Wupatki (time permitting); coal-mine-canyon
3/4	26–27. 7.	Ne	1→2	✓ Coral Pink Sand Dunes CG	moenave-dinosaur-tracks , navajo-bridge ; white-pocket if time allows (no permit)
4/5	27–28. 7.	Po	2	✓ Kodachrome Basin SP	coral-pink-sand-dunes morning; bryce-canyon
5/6	28–29. 7.	Út	2	✓ Stateline Campground	kodachrome-basin , Grosvenor Arch, cottonwood-canyon-road
6/7	29–30. 7.	St	2→3	✓ Stateline Campground	Rest day / explore House Rock Valley area
7/8	30–31. 7.	Čt	3	✓ Stateline Campground	⚠ CBS permit — hike coyote-buttessouth (Paw Hole)
8/9	31. 7.–1. 8.	Pá	3	? Alstrom Point (BLM dispersed)	Drive east; alstrom-point overlook
9/10	1–2. 8.	So	3	? Smokey Mountain Road area or Escalante	smokey-mountain-road ; resupply escalante
10/11	2–3. 8.	Ne	3	? Capitol Reef / Boulder area	muley-twist-canyon (Upper); or The Wave if permit won
11/12	3–4. 8.	Po	3→4	✓ Goblin Valley SP Campground	horseshoe-canyon Great Gallery (morning); drive to goblin-valley

Night	Date	Day	Segment	Campground	Key activity
12/13	4–5. 8.	Út	4	? Moonscape Overlook (BLM dispersed)	goblin-valley morning; moonscape-overlook
13/14	5–6. 8.	St	4	✓ Cathedral Valley Campground	cathedral-valley circuit; Hartnet Road
14/15	6–7. 8.	Čt	4	✓ Henry Mountains — McMillan Spring area	bentonite-hills ; lower Henry Mtns access
15/16	7–8. 8.	Pá	4	✓ Henry Mountains — McMillan Spring area	Mt. Pennell hike; bison; henry-mountains
16/17	8–9. 8.	So	4→5	✓ Dead Horse Point SP	green-river-overlook (time permitting); transit from Henry Mountains (~4 h); stage for White Rim
17/18	9–10. 8.	Ne	5	✓ Dead Horse Point SP	Rest day; Shafer Trail viewpoint from above
18/19	10–11. 8.	Po	5	✓ White Crack Campground	⚠ White Rim permit — Shafer Trail descent
19/20	11–12. 8.	Út	5	? Comb Wash CG (Nizhoni CG confirmed closed — babylon-fire)	⚠ White Rim permit — Mineral Bottom exit; newspaper-rock (UT-211) only if verified open ; back to US-191, drive south
20/21	12–13. 8.	St	5→6	✓ Monument Valley (The View / Navajo CG)	🔥 babylon-fire reroute v2: US-191 → US-163 via Bluff; navajo-rug and/or valley-of-the-gods ; muley-point via Moki Dugway from south — go/no-go on the spot per cloud/smoke seen from the Valley
21/22	13–14. 8.	Čt	6	? Surprise camping OR Blackhawk Loop CG	monument-valley sunrise; drive to Clarkdale (valley-of-the-gods already done Aug 12); verde-canyon-railroad 13:00–17:00 — 🔥 at risk from pocket-fire ; if affected, skip Sedona + train
22/23	14–15. 8.	Pá	6	✓ Twin Peaks Campground (Organ Pipe NM)	grand-canyon-desert-view ; sedona (🔥 conditional on pocket-fire); drive south
23/24	15–16. 8.	So	6	✓ Hilton Phoenix Airport	organ-pipe-cactus-nm ; kitt-peak ; drive to PHX
—	16. 8.	Ne	—	Departure PHX 09:00	—

Resolved planning notes

Night 0/1 (23/24 Jul) — Gilbert Ray Campground (Tucson Mountain Park) is **closed**; only BLM dispersed sites remain in the area and those have no valid registration/address. The first night in the U.S. must have a specifiable street address (required for arrival paperwork), so plan is a motel in Tucson — presumably a Wyndham property near Costco. **Open item**: confirm the exact hotel and address before travel (source: user update 2026-07-05).

Night 1/2 (24/25 Jul) — Christopher Creek CG (Tonto National Forest, near Payson) or dispersed on the Mogollon Rim Road (FR-300). Book ahead if NF campground.

Night 3/4 (26/27 Jul) — Drive straight from Navajo Bridge area to Coral Pink Sand Dunes. **white-pocket** can be a day stop en route if time permits (no permit needed, high-clearance 4WD only). Arrival at Coral Pink late afternoon.

Segment 4 alternative (Hanksville area, ~4-8 Aug) — Optional **orange-cliffs-loop**: east off UT-95 via BLM 15000 (Cedar Point and/or Poison Spring Canyon, Dirty Devil ford) to a campsite around Land's End or the Happy Canyon campsite, then the Flint Trail. Possibility only — would replace or displace 1-2 nights currently at Moonscape / Henry Mountains; likely needs an Orange Cliffs backcountry permit (source: user request 2026-07-05).

Nights 16/17 and 17/18 (8-10 Aug) — Two nights at Dead Horse Point State Park. Drive from Henry Mountains on August 8 (~4 hours). Night 9/10 is a rest day with a view of the Shafer Trail rim from above, before descending on August 10.

Nights 19/20-20/21 (11-13 Aug) — Babylon fire reroute (v2, 2026-07-05) — The **babylon-fire** has closed the Needles district and the whole Monticello Ranger District. **The entire Bears Ears section is now dropped by decision** — even with containment, firefighter traffic, burned forest, and residual closures are expected; this removes Elk Ridge / Horse Mountain, **natural-bridges-nm**, and the northern Cedar Mesa crossing. Instead, Aug 12 runs: **newspaper-rock only if verified open**, then US-191 south → US-163 through Bluff → Mexican Hat area: **navajo-rug** (Raplee Anticline) and/or **valley-of-the-gods** (east entrance), then **muley-point** as an out-and-back up the Moki Dugway from the south — **decided on arrival, based on cloud/smoke coverage over Cedar Mesa as visible from the Valley of the Gods → monument-valley** for the night. The southern approach is modestly faster than the original northern crossing (the slow UT-95 segment and Natural Bridges detour disappear). Doing Valley of the Gods on Aug 12 also frees the Aug 13 morning for the drive to the Clarkdale train. Nizhoni CG (Abajo Mountains) is **confirmed inside the closure** — the entire Monticello Ranger District is closed and Needles permits are cancelled through July 31 (web check 2026-07-05: ~87,500 acres, 0% contained, growing north). Comb Wash CG (BLM) is the night 19/20 plan; verify it stays outside the closure. North of the Colorado — White Rim, Island in the Sky, Dead Horse Point — is unaffected except possible smoke; White Crack faces the fire direction, so check smoke forecasts before the Aug 10 descent.

Night 20/21 (12/13 Aug) — Monument Valley. Depart by 08:00 on August 13 to reach Clarkdale for the 13:00 train. **natural-bridges-nm** on August 12 is optional — skip if the day is full.

Permit dates — confirmed

Permit	Date	Notes
Coyote Buttes South (Paw Hole)	30. 7. 2026 (Čt)	Base: Stateline Campground (two nights: 29/30 and 30/31)
White Rim Road	10. 8. 2026 (Po) — first night White Crack	Shafer Trail entry; see permits
White Rim Road	11. 8. 2026 (Út) — exit via Mineral Bottom	Second permit night

Segment summary

Segment	Dates	Nights	Campgrounds
1	23-26. 7.	3	Motel Tucson ? (address TBD) · Christopher Creek CG ✓ · Coal Mine Canyon ✓
1→2	26-27. 7.	1	Coral Pink Sand Dunes CG ✓
2	27-29. 7.	3	Kodachrome Basin SP ✓ · Stateline ✓ · Stateline ✓
3	30. 7.-3. 8.	5	Stateline ✓ · Alstrom ? · Smokey Mtn ? · Capitol Reef ? · Goblin Valley ✓
4	3-8. 8.	5	Goblin Valley ✓ · Moonscape ? · Cathedral Valley ✓ · Henrys x2 ✓ · alt: orange-cliffs-loop

Segment	Dates	Nights	Campgrounds
4→5	8–10. 8.	2	Dead Horse Point SP  ×2
5	10–12. 8.	3	White Crack  · Comb Wash  (Nizhoni confirmed closed — babylon-fire) · Monument Valley 
6	13–15. 8.	3	Surprise/Blackhawk  · Twin Peaks  · Hilton PHX 

Total nights: 24 (July 23 to August 15 inclusive) **Total days:** 25 (arrival July 23 to departure August 16)

August 13 timing note — Verde Canyon Railroad

 **Pocket fire caveat:** the **pocket-fire** burns ~7 mi **north** of Sedona (31% contained as of 2026-07-05); Clarkdale is west, so the train is plausibly unaffected — but confirm with the railroad before the trip. **SR-89A through Oak Creek Canyon is closed:** approach Clarkdale via I-17 south → AZ-260 (Camp Verde) → Cottonwood instead. If the train is cancelled or the area is smoked out, skip Sedona and the train — Aug 13 then frees up and **grand-canyon-desert-view** fits naturally that day instead. Note the Sedona town stop is doubtful in every scenario: the scenic 89A approach is closed and firefighters reportedly expect the fire to move south toward Sedona's surroundings (source: user update 2026-07-05; web check 2026-07-05).

The train departs Clarkdale at **13:00** and returns at **17:00**. Clarkdale is ~25 minutes from **sedona** and ~30 minutes from Cottonwood.

If camping at **Monument Valley** (night 12/13): depart 08:00 → Monument Valley photos at sunrise → drive US-163 → US-160 → US-89 → I-17 → AZ-260 → Clarkdale (**valley-of-the-gods** is now done on Aug 12, which relaxes this morning). ~4.5 hours driving. Depart by 08:00 = arrive Clarkdale ~12:30. Feasible with margin.

If camping at **Muley Point** (night 12/13): ~6 hours to Clarkdale. Must depart by 06:30. Very early start; not recommended.

Grand Canyon Desert View on this day is difficult to combine with the train. Consider visiting Desert View on August 14 morning (Sedona → Desert View is ~2 hours north; then south to Organ Pipe). Or skip and see the canyon from the road overlooks en route.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [casovy-rozvrh](#)
- [babylon-fire](#)
- [pocket-fire](#)
- [permits](#)
- [orange-cliffs-loop](#)
- [coyote-buttes-south](#)
- [white-rim-road](#)
- [muley-point](#)
- [verde-canyon-railroad](#)
- [henry-mountains](#)
- [goblin-valley](#)

Utah Trip Itinerary

Summary: Complete loop from Phoenix covering southern Utah, the Colorado Plateau, and canyon country — July 23 to August 16, 2026 (25 days, 24 nights).

Sources: All six KMZ route files in raw/; raw/Časový rozvrh (see **casovy-rozvrh**); user update 2026-07-05.

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Overview

Departure: Thursday 23. 7. 2026, arrive PHX 19:00 **Return flight:** Sunday 16. 8. 2026, depart PHX 09:00

A clockwise loop departing and returning to Phoenix Sky Harbor (PHX). The route threads through Navajo and Hopi land, the Vermilion Cliffs, Grand Staircase-Escalante, Capitol Reef country, the Henry Mountains, Canyonlands, and Monument Valley before looping back through the Grand Canyon and Sonoran Desert.

For the full day-by-day calendar with campgrounds, see **schedule**. Three stops require advance permits — see **permits** for booking details.

Confirmed permit dates: CBS Paw Hole 30. 7., White Rim Road 10.–11. 8. **No permit needed:** White Pocket (free access, 4WD only)

Leg 1 — PHX to Tuba City

Source: *Directions from Phoenix Sky Harbor...to Navajo Moenave Dinosaur Tracks.kmz*

End point: Moenave Dinosaur Tracks, Tuba City, AZ

Stop	Notes
Motel Tucson (first night)	Gilbert Ray CG is closed — replaced by motel, presumably a Wyndham property near Costco; address TBD (source: user update 2026-07-05)
Apache Junction, AZ	Gateway to the Superstitions
apache-trail (AZ-88)	Unpaved switchback road above Canyon Lake; narrow
Roosevelt Dam	End of the Apache Trail; paved from here
mogollon-rim	High-country escarpment above the Sonoran desert
meteor-crater	50,000-year-old impact site; private land, entry fee
sunset-crater & Wupatki NM	Cinder cone volcano + Ancestral Puebloan ruins on US-89; time permitting
coal-mine-canyon	Isolated Navajo land canyon; rim camping available
moenave-dinosaur-tracks	Free Navajo-guided site; final stop before Tuba City

Leg 2 — Tuba City to Stateline Campground

Source: *Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz*

End point: Stateline Campground, House Rock Valley Road, UT

Stop	Notes
navajo-bridge	Twin spans over the Colorado at Marble Canyon

Stop	Notes
white-pocket	No permit required; high-clearance 4WD on deep sand
kanab	Last town with full services before Grand Staircase
coral-pink-sand-dunes	State park; OHV area and short hike
bryce-canyon	Hoodoo amphitheaters; entry fee, busy in summer
kodachrome-basin	Sedimentary spires; quieter than Bryce
Grosvenor Arch	Double arch; free, short walk from road
cottonwood-canyon-road	Dirt road south through Grand Staircase; high-clearance
Stateline Campground	Free BLM; base for Coyote Buttes South

Leg 3 — Stateline to Goblin Valley

Source: *Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz*

End point: Goblin Valley State Park, UT

Stop	Notes
coyote-buttes-south (Paw Hole)	Permit required — Recreation.gov lottery
alstrom-point	Dramatic Lake Powell overlook; high-clearance road
smokey-mountain-road	Remote dirt road across Kaiparowits
escalante	Petrified Forest SP; town services
muley-twist-canyon	Capitol Reef backcountry; Upper Muley Twist
hanksville	Resupply town; junction for Henry Mountains and Horseshoe Canyon
horseshoe-canyon — Great Gallery	Detached Canyonlands unit; UT-24 → W Lower San Rafael Road (CR-1000); ~6.5 mi RT hike
Long Dong Silver Trailhead	Hanksville area access road
Mars Desert Research Station	Visible from highway near Hanksville
goblin-valley	State park; bizarre mushroom-rock formations

Leg 4 — Goblin Valley to Mt. Pennell

Source: *Directions from Goblin Valley State Park...to Mt. Pennell Lookout.kmz*

End point: Mt. Pennell Lookout, Henry Mountains, UT

Stop	Notes
moonscape-overlook	San Rafael Swell views; accessible dirt road
cathedral-valley	Northern Capitol Reef; monolith formations
Cathedral Valley Campground	Free primitive; no water
Hartnet Cathedral Road	Rough 4WD connector through Capitol Reef backcountry
bentonite-hills	Technicolor badlands; best in low light
McMillan Spring Road Turnoff	Access into Henry Mountains high country
henry-mountains — Mt. Pennell	Remote summit; free-roaming bison herd

Alternative: orange-cliffs-loop — optional loop from Hanksville via BLM 15000 (Cedar Point / Poison Spring Canyon) to Land's End or Happy Canyon campsite, then the Flint Trail. Possibility only; would displace 1–2 Segment 4 nights (source: user request 2026-07-05).

Leg 5 — Hanksville to Muley Point

Source: *Directions from BLM 0095, Hanksville...to Muley Point East.kmz*

End point: Muley Point East, UT

Stop	Notes
green-river-overlook	Island in the Sky, Canyonlands; rim view to White Rim and Green River below; time permitting on transit day
Dead Horse Point SP	Two-night base before White Rim descent
white-rim-road via Shafer Trail	Permit required — Canyonlands backcountry
White Crack	Mid-road camp and viewpoint
Mineral Bottom Switchbacks	Dramatic descent to Green River
newspaper-rock	Dense petroglyph panel on UT-211; free roadside stop on exit day — if open during babylon-fire closure
Horse Mountain	High point between Canyonlands and Natural Bridges Dropped — Elk Ridge crossing blocked by babylon-fire closure (source: user update 2026-07-05)
natural-bridges-nm	Dropped with the Bears Ears section — babylon-fire aftermath: firefighter traffic, burned forest (source: user decision 2026-07-05)
muley-point	Kept: out-and-back from the south via Moki Dugway from valley-of-the-gods west entrance; go/no-go on the spot per cloud/smoke visible from the Valley
navajo-rug	Raplee Anticline near Mexican Hat — replacement stop on US-163 (needs user confirmation of identification)

Fire reroute v2 (Aug 12): the entire Bears Ears section is dropped — even if the **babylon-fire** is contained, firefighter traffic and burned forest are expected. Leg 5 now runs Newspaper Rock (if open) → US-191 → US-163 via Bluff → **navajo-rug** and/or **valley-of-the-gods** → **monument-valley** (source: user decision 2026-07-05).

Leg 6 — Muley Point to PHX

Source: *Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz*

End point: Phoenix Sky Harbor International Airport (PHX)

Stop	Notes
valley-of-the-gods	17-mile dirt loop through sandstone buttes; free BLM — moved to Aug 12 (Leg 5 reroute)
monument-valley	Navajo Nation Tribal Park; entry fee
grand-canyon-desert-view	South Rim east entrance; Watchtower overlook
sedona	Red rock town; galleries, hiking — 🔥 conditional: skip if pocket-fire affects the area
verde-canyon-railroad	4-hour scenic train from Clarkdale — 🔥 at risk from pocket-fire ; verify operating status before Aug 13

Stop	Notes
organ-pipe-cactus-nm	Sonoran Desert biosphere; remote south of Ajo
kitt-peak	National Observatory; night-sky programs

Permit summary

Permit	Date	Notes
Coyote Buttes South	30. 7. 2026	Recreation.gov lottery — confirmed; see permits
White Rim Road	10.–11. 8. 2026	Recreation.gov permit — confirmed; see permits

Related pages

- **permits**
- **apache-trail**
- **white-pocket**
- **coyote-buttles-south**
- **white-rim-road**
- **henry-mountains**
- **monument-valley**

Permits

Summary: Two stops on this trip require advance permits booked through Recreation.gov: Coyote Buttes South (July 30) and White Rim Road (Aug 10–11). White Pocket does not require a permit. A third, conditional permit (Orange Cliffs camping) applies only if the **orange-cliffs-loop** option is taken.

Sources: raw/ KMZ route files (location identification); raw/Časový rozvrh (see **casovy-rozvrh**); user request 2026-07-05; permit details need verification against current Recreation.gov listings.

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Coyote Buttes South (Paw Hole)

Trip leg: **itinerary** Leg 3 **Permit date:** **30. 7. 2026 (Thursday)** — confirmed **Location:** Paria Canyon-Vermilion Cliffs Wilderness, AZ/UT border **Permit unit:** Coyote Buttes South

Coyote Buttes South (CBS) is the less-visited complement to Coyote Buttes North (The Wave). Paw Hole is the main attraction: a bowl of crinkled, candy-striped Navajo Sandstone. Quota is roughly 10 permits per day (needs verification).

- Booking: Recreation.gov — "Coyote Buttes South" (needs verification)
- Daily lottery draws 4 months ahead and online day-before lottery
- Base camp at Stateline Campground (free BLM, ~10 sites)
- Trailhead at Wire Pass or House Rock Valley Road (needs verification)

See also: **coyote-butttes-south**

White Rim Road

Trip leg: **itinerary** Leg 5 **Permit dates:** **10. 8. 2026 (Monday)** — White Crack camp; **11. 8. 2026 (Tuesday)** — Mineral Bottom exit — confirmed **Location:** Canyonlands National Park — Island in the Sky District, UT **Permit unit:** White Rim Road Motorized

The White Rim Road is a 100-mile dirt loop around the Island in the Sky mesa at ~1,200 ft above the Colorado and Green rivers. Route on this trip enters via Shafer Trail (from Moab/US-191) and exits at Mineral Bottom. Allow 3 days minimum by 4WD.

Key waypoints on route (source: BLM 0095 Hanksville to Muley Point.kmz): - Shafer Trail Viewpoint — top of the canyon rim descent - White Crack — popular mid-trip campsite - Mineral Bottom Switchbacks — exit via Green River side

- Booking: Recreation.gov — "White Rim Road" permit (needs verification)
- Permits required for overnight use; day trips also may require entry reservation (needs verification)
- No water along route; carry all water
- NPS entrance fee applies (America the Beautiful pass accepted)

See also: **white-rim-road**, **muley-point**

Conditional: Orange Cliffs backcountry camping

Trip leg: alternative around Hanksville — see **orange-cliffs-loop** **Status:** only needed if the loop option is taken; no date set

Designated vehicle campsites in the Orange Cliffs Unit of Glen Canyon NRA (including Happy Canyon and Land's End) are believed to require a backcountry permit issued through Canyonlands NP, similar to Maze district permits (needs verification — check with Hans Flat Ranger Station / Recreation.gov). If the loop replaces Segment 4 nights, book this before firming up the **schedule** change (source: user request 2026-07-05).

Booking strategy

Coyote Buttes South (July 30) and White Rim Road (Aug 10–11) are confirmed. White Pocket date is not yet set — see gaps in **schedule**.

The CBS permit anchors Segment 3 to the July 30 date. All segment 3 campground bookings should be made with that fixed point in mind.

White Rim Road entry is via Shafer Trail on August 10; exit via Mineral Bottom on August 11. The night of August 9 (Wild Horse SP / Dead Horse Point) is the staging camp before the descent.

See **schedule** for the full day-by-day calendar and unresolved gaps.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **orange-cliffs-loop**
- **white-pocket**
- **coyote-buttes-south**
- **white-rim-road**
- **kanab**

Babylon Fire (2026)

Summary: Wildfire burning south of the Needles district of Canyonlands as of early July 2026, with an area closure currently in effect until end of July. It forces a reroute of the Aug 11–13 days: skip the Elk Ridge / Bears Ears backcountry crossing and use highways US-191 → UT-95 → UT-261 instead.

Sources: User update (2026-07-05); web check 2026-07-05 (moabsunnews.com, kutv.com, fox13now.com, abc4.com, sltrib.com). Status is a snapshot — re-verify closer to the trip.

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Situation

- Fire is located **south of the Needles district** of Canyonlands (source: user update 2026-07-05)
- The area is **closed until end of July 2026**; it is not a good bet that it will be accessible around **August 12/13** as the plan requires (source: user update 2026-07-05)
- The closure blocks the planned **Bears Ears route after leaving Moab** — the Leg 5 KMZ crossing over Elk Ridge past Horse Mountain toward **natural-bridges-nm** (source: user update 2026-07-05; route from Leg 5 KMZ)

Verified status (web check, 2026-07-05)

Per Moab Sun News / KUTV / Fox13 / ABC4 / Salt Lake Tribune, checked 2026-07-05:

- **~87,500 acres, 0% contained** — among the largest fires in the nation; burning ~25 miles southwest of Monticello in the Manti-La Sal NF near Blanding and Bears Ears NM
- The **Needles district of Canyonlands NP is closed** until further notice; all Needles day-use and overnight backcountry permits and campground reservations **cancelled through July 31, 2026**
- The fire has been **growing north**, prompting the Canyonlands closure
- The Forest Service closure covers the **entire Monticello Ranger District** — reported as "all federal lands south of Highway 211." This **confirms Nizhoni CG (Abajo Mountains) is inside the closure**. Whether the phrase covers BLM lands (Comb Wash CG) or only Forest Service lands needs verification — if BLM lands south of UT-211 are included, night 19/20 options and the exact closure boundary need a fresh look closer to the trip

North of the Colorado — assessment

The user's assumption (2026-07-05): the fire should not cross the Colorado River, so everything north of it should be unaffected except perhaps smoke. This looks right:

- **white-rim-road**, Island in the Sky, **green-river-overlook**, and Dead Horse Point SP all lie **north-west of the Colorado's canyon** — a major natural firebreak between them and the fire. The NPS closure covers **only the Needles district**; no Island in the Sky or White Rim closures were found (web check 2026-07-05)
- **Smoke is the realistic risk — and it is a viewing problem, not a safety problem:** White Crack camp (night 18/19) sits at the southern tip of the White Rim looking directly toward the confluence and the Needles. The fire is ~40+ miles away across the river canyon; at that distance smoke means haze that flattens the long views and perhaps a smoky smell — not anything threatening survival or breathing. The only caveat: on a bad day (dense smoke drift, overnight inversion settling into the canyons) air quality could reach "unhealthy for sensitive groups" levels, which for a 7-year-old would mean an unpleasant night rather than a dangerous one. If the forecast looks bad, it is a comfort decision, not an evacuation-grade concern (assessment 2026-07-05; check a smoke/AQ forecast before the Aug 10 descent)

Impact on the plan

Planned element	Status
Elk Ridge / Horse Mountain crossing (Leg 5 KMZ route)	Dropped — inside/behind the closure
newspaper-rock (UT-211)	Genuinely uncertain — the closure boundary now reaches Highway 211 itself and the fire is growing north. Keep only if verified open at trip time; be ready to drop it without regret
Nizhoni CG (night 19/20 option, Abajo Mountains)	Confirmed inside the closure (entire Monticello Ranger District closed — web check 2026-07-05). Use Comb Wash CG (BLM) instead — believed outside the FS closure, but verify whether the closure extends to BLM lands south of UT-211
Entire Bears Ears section (UT-95 corridor, natural-bridges-nm , Cedar Mesa crossing via UT-261 from the north)	Dropped by decision (2026-07-05) — even if the fire is contained by mid-August, firefighter traffic, burned forest, and residual closures make it unattractive. Replaced by the Mexican Hat area (below)
valley-of-the-gods , navajo-rug (Mexican Hat area), monument-valley	New Aug 12 plan — reached entirely via US-191 → US-163 through Bluff; no forest, fully clear of the fire area
muley-point	Kept (decided 2026-07-05) — southern out-and-back via UT-261 / Moki Dugway from the Valley of the Gods west entrance; no burned country. Go/no-go decided on arrival based on cloud/smoke coverage visible from the Valley

Reroute (Aug 12) — revised 2026-07-05

~~First version: US-191 → UT-95 → Natural Bridges → UT-261 across Cedar Mesa to Muley Point.~~

Superseded — the whole Bears Ears section is out of the question even if the fire is contained: firefighter traffic, burned forest, and residual restrictions are expected to linger (source: user decision 2026-07-05).

Current plan: after **newspaper-rock** (only if verified open), stay on **US-191 south, then US-163 through Bluff to the Mexican Hat area:** the **navajo-rug** (Raplee Anticline) along the San Juan and/or the **valley-of-the-gods** loop (entered from the US-163 east entrance), then on to **monument-valley** for night 20/21. Entirely highway + open BLM desert; no fire-area exposure. Optional variant: **muley-point** as an out-and-back from the Valley of the Gods west entrance via the Moki Dugway (UT-261 from the south) — to be decided.

Side benefit: with **valley-of-the-gods** done on Aug 12, the Aug 13 morning frees up — depart Monument Valley straight for the Clarkdale train without the previously planned quick VotG loop.

Before the trip

- Check fire status and closure boundary (InciWeb, BLM Monticello, Manti-La Sal NF alerts)
- Confirm whether UT-211 / Newspaper Rock is open
- Confirm Comb Wash CG is outside the closure (Nizhoni CG is confirmed closed)
- Check smoke forecast for the White Rim days (Aug 10–11), especially White Crack
- **Watch item — Henry Mountains:** given the extreme dryness, new fire starts are possible anywhere in the region, including the **henry-mountains** (Aug 6–8 camps). Nothing has happened there so far (source: user update 2026-07-05), but re-check BLM Utah fire news and fire restrictions (campfire bans likely) before the trip

Related pages

- **schedule**
- **itinerary**

- **newspaper-rock**
- **natural-bridges-nm**
- **muley-point**

Pocket Fire (2026)

Summary: Wildfire in the Sedona area as of early July 2026, expected to burn for months until monsoon rains stop it. Puts the Aug 13 **verde-canyon-railroad** ride in doubt; if the train is affected, the plan is presumably to skip **sedona** entirely.

Sources: User update (2026-07-05); web check 2026-07-05 (ein.az.gov, fs.usda.gov/r03/coconino, visitsedona.com, verdecanyonrr.com). Status is a snapshot — re-verify closer to the trip.

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Situation

- Fire is burning in the **sedona** area; estimated to last **months** — likely until monsoon rains stop it (source: user update 2026-07-05)
- It is **unclear whether the Verde Canyon Railroad ride (Aug 13) is affected**. The hope is that the railroad canyon is not affected and is actually outside the smoke area, but this is not known (source: user update 2026-07-05)
- Geography in our favor: the train runs from Clarkdale **northwest into Verde Canyon toward Perkinsville** — a different canyon from Oak Creek/Sedona, on the far side of the Verde Valley (~20 miles west of Sedona). Being outside the burn area is plausible, but valley smoke could still matter (needs verification)
- **⚠ Southward spread expected:** media report that firefighters presume the fire will move **toward the south** — i.e. toward the Sedona surroundings. This makes the Sedona visit itself more doubtful, and could eventually push smoke into the Verde Valley as well (source: user update 2026-07-05, citing media; needs verification against official spread projections)

Verified status (web check, 2026-07-05)

Per AZ Emergency Information Network / Coconino NF (sources: ein.az.gov, fs.usda.gov, checked 2026-07-05):

- Fire is ~7 miles **north** of Sedona, in the **Red Rock-Secret Mountain Wilderness**; ~25,160 acres, **31% contained**, 1,089 personnel
- Oak Creek Canyon was evacuated and remains in **SET** status; Forest Highlands, Kachina Village, and Pine Del downgraded to **READY**
- **SR-89A is closed to non-local traffic between Sedona and I-17** (the Oak Creek Canyon stretch); Woody Mountain Road / FR-231 also closed
- The fire is on the **opposite side of Sedona from Clarkdale** — the Verde Canyon Railroad's 2026 schedule remains published, and no railroad closure was found, but **no explicit confirmation it is unaffected**; confirm directly with the railroad before Aug 13

Routing implication for Aug 13: the usual descent to Sedona/Clarkdale via US-89A through Oak Creek Canyon is closed. From Flagstaff, take **I-17 south to AZ-260 (Camp Verde exit) → Cottonwood → Clarkdale** instead — roughly comparable time, and it bypasses both the closure and the smoke source area (needs verification of closure status in August).

Decision tree for Aug 13

Scenario	Plan
Train running, air acceptable	Keep the train: depart Monument Valley 08:00, train 13:00-17:00 from Clarkdale via the I-17 → AZ-260 → Cottonwood approach. The Sedona stop itself is a separate, weaker case: with SR-89A / Oak Creek Canyon closed, the scenic approach is gone — going via Sedona without 89A "would be a pity" but loses much of its point, and with the fire expected to move south toward Sedona's surroundings, the town visit is likely off regardless (source: user update 2026-07-05)

Scenario	Plan
Train cancelled or smoked out	Skip Sedona and the train. Aug 13 frees up ~5 hours — grand-canyon-desert-view then fits naturally on Aug 13 (currently flagged as hard to combine with the train), continuing south on Aug 14 toward organ-pipe-cactus-nm with time to spare (possibility, not decided)

Before the trip

- Check Verde Canyon Railroad operating status directly (website/phone) shortly before Aug 13 — and whether refunds/rebooking apply if smoke worsens
- Check Coconino NF closure orders and smoke forecasts for the Sedona / Verde Valley area
- Decide the fallback shape of Aug 13–14 only once the train status is known

Related pages

- [schedule](#)
- [itinerary](#)
- [verde-canyon-railroad](#)
- [sedona](#)
- [grand-canyon-desert-view](#)
- [babylon-fire](#)

Kids on the Trip

Summary: Child-friendly highlights along the full loop for a 7-year-old, organized by theme — dinosaurs, live animals, hands-on experiences, and easy walks.

Sources: raw/ KMZ route files (location identification); activity suitability notes are general knowledge (needs verification for current programming and access).

Last updated: 2026-05-20.

Dinosaurs and ancient life

Moenave Dinosaur Tracks — Leg 1

The single best stop for a dinosaur-obsessed 7-year-old. A Navajo guide walks you across a sandstone ledge covered in three-toed theropod footprints made roughly 190 million years ago. The guide often points out tracks mid-stride, showing how the animal was moving. Free; tips for the guide are expected and appropriate. See [moenave-dinosaur-tracks](#).

Newspaper Rock — Leg 5

Hundreds of petroglyphs carved by different peoples over 2,000 years on a single dark rock panel. Animals are easy to identify — bighorn sheep, deer, birds — and the variety of styles from different eras makes it feel like a real storybook. Free, roadside, 20 minutes. See [newspaper-rock](#).

Horseshoe Canyon — Great Gallery — Leg 3

Life-sized ghostly figures painted on a canyon wall by Archaic-period people 2,000–4,000 years ago. These are pictographs (painted, not carved), and the scale is what makes them unforgettable — some figures stand 6–7 feet tall with hollow eyes and no legs, like something out of a dream. The hike to reach them is about 6.5 miles round trip with a real descent into the canyon; long for a 7-year-old but memorable. See [horseshoe-canyon](#).

Sunset Crater Volcano & Wupatki — Leg 1

Two stops in quick succession on US-89 north of Flagstaff. At Sunset Crater, kids walk on real solidified lava — chunky, alien terrain from an eruption less than 1,000 years ago. At Wupatki, they see multi-story ancient rooms still standing, a ball court, and a blow hole in the ground that breathes air in or out as weather changes — reliably surprising. Both are short flat walks. See [sunset-crater](#).

Escalante Petrified Forest State Park — Leg 3

Not dinosaurs, but ancient trees turned to stone — some specimens are large enough to impress a child. The trail loops past petrified wood on a hillside overlooking a reservoir. Short and easy. See [escalante](#).

Goblin Valley State Park — Leg 3

The "goblins" are the eroded remains of a 170-million-year-old seafloor. No fossils on display, but kids love the formation story and the visual — hundreds of mushroom-shaped rocks they can climb on freely. One of the top stops on the whole trip for children. See [goblin-valley](#).

Live animals and wildlife

Henry Mountains — Bison herd — Leg 4

A free-roaming herd of approximately 300–400 bison lives year-round on BLM land in the Henry Mountains (needs verification). These are wild animals on open land — sightings from a vehicle are common along the mountain access roads, and there is no fence between you and them. Seeing

American bison up close in the wild is a genuinely memorable experience for a child. See **henry-mountains**.

Navajo Bridge — California Condors — Leg 2

California condors — the largest flying land bird in North America, wingspan up to 9.5 feet (needs verification) — soost on the bridge structure and soar above the Colorado River gorge. Marble Canyon is one of the most reliable condor viewing spots in the country (needs verification). The birds are enormous, easily visible, and sometimes perch just a few feet above the walkway. See **navajo-bridge**.

Bryce Canyon — Prairie dogs — Leg 2

Prairie dog towns are active near the visitor center and along the rim road. 7-year-olds reliably find them delightful. See **bryce-canyon**.

Organ Pipe Cactus NM — Desert wildlife — Leg 6

Gila woodpeckers nesting in cactus arms, Gambel's quail, roadrunners, Gila monsters (rare), and in warm evenings, elf owls in saguaro cavities. The Ajo Mountain Drive provides good wildlife viewing from a vehicle. See **organ-pipe-cactus-nm**.

Monument Valley — Navajo horses — Leg 6

Horses graze freely in and around the valley. On the 17-Mile Drive, it's common to see horses close to the road. See **monument-valley**.

White Rim Road — Desert bighorn sheep — Leg 5

Desert bighorn sheep are frequently seen on the canyon walls of the White Rim. Also look for ravens, canyon wrens, and occasionally coyotes or mule deer. See **white-rim-road**.

Best stops for kids — overall ranking

Rank	Stop	Why
1	goblin-valley	Free climbing on hundreds of formations; totally safe; magical
2	moenave-dinosaur-tracks	Real dinosaur footprints with a live guide
3	verde-canyon-railroad	4-hour train ride through a wild canyon
4	coral-pink-sand-dunes	Playing in sand dunes
5	henry-mountains	Wild bison from the car
6	navajo-bridge	Condors soaring overhead
7	natural-bridges-nm	Walking under enormous natural bridges
8	bryce-canyon	Hoodoos + prairie dogs
9	monument-valley	Iconic views; easy to understand grandeur
10	kitt-peak	Observatory; nighttime viewing programs

Best hikes for a 7-year-old

These trails are short, low-hazard, and visually rewarding:

- **Goblin Valley main basin** — short flat walk into the formations; no trail needed (see **goblin-valley**)
- **Bryce Canyon Queen's Garden trail** — descends into hoodoos; 1.8 miles RT from Sunrise Point (needs verification); moderate but manageable with breaks
- **Natural Bridges loop segments** — each bridge can be reached separately; Owachomo Bridge is the shortest descent (~0.4 miles RT, needs verification)

- **Coral Pink Sand Dunes** — no trail; just walk up the dunes; exhausting in a fun way
 - **Navajo Bridge pedestrian walkway** — flat, 5 minutes, great condor views
-

Train ride

verde-canyon-railroad — Leg 6 — is the only train on the trip and one of the best child-friendly activities. ⚠️ Note: the ride is at risk from the **pocket-fire** near Sedona — verify operating status before promising it to a 7-year-old (source: user update 2026-07-05). The 4-hour round trip through the Verde Canyon is entirely car-based (no hiking required), has open-air viewing cars, and passes through dramatic red-rock scenery. Bald eagles are sometimes visible in winter. Book tickets in advance.

Difficulty notes — what might be hard for a 7-year-old

- **White Rim Road** (Leg 5): 3-day 4WD route; long dusty driving days, no facilities, no shade. Manageable if the child is comfortable with long car days and camping without hookups. Pack entertainment for the driving sections.
 - **Smokey Mountain Road** (Leg 3): 3-4 hours of remote, rough dirt road. Similar issue — long with nothing to do outside the car.
 - **Coyote Buttes South / Paw Hole** (Leg 3): ~5 miles of trackless slickrock in full sun. Doable for a fit 7-year-old but demanding. Start very early; carry plenty of water.
 - **Cathedral Valley** (Leg 4): long rough approach roads; the formations themselves are awe-inspiring but the drive is tiring.
-

Practical tips

- Carry a dedicated "road bag" with activities, snacks, and headphones — many legs have long driving segments with no services
 - The Henry Mountains bison are best seen by driving slowly along the mountain access roads in early morning or evening
 - Goblin Valley allows children to climb freely on the formations — unlike most NPS sites this is explicitly permitted
 - Condors at Navajo Bridge are easier to see with binoculars; worth packing a cheap pair for the trip
 - Bryce Canyon has junior ranger programs at the visitor center (needs verification)
 - Natural Bridges has a junior ranger program as well (needs verification)
-

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **moenave-dinosaur-tracks**
- **goblin-valley**
- **henry-mountains**
- **navajo-bridge**
- **bryce-canyon**
- **verde-canyon-railroad**
- **coral-pink-sand-dunes**
- **natural-bridges-nm**
- **organ-pipe-cactus-nm**

Apache Trail

Summary: Historic dirt road (AZ-88) through the Superstition Wilderness above Canyon Lake, connecting Apache Junction to Roosevelt Dam.

Sources: raw/Directions from Phoenix Sky Harbor...to Navajo Moenave Dinosaur Tracks.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Route

The Apache Trail (AZ-88) begins at Apache Junction east of Phoenix and follows a narrow unpaved road above Canyon Lake, Fish Creek Canyon, and Apache Lake before reaching Roosevelt Dam. The eastern section from Fish Creek Hill to Roosevelt is unpaved and one lane wide with passing turnouts; high-clearance vehicles are recommended, though most passenger cars can make it slowly (needs verification).

Distance: approximately 40 miles, Apache Junction to Roosevelt Dam (needs verification).

Roosevelt Dam

Roosevelt Dam sits at the east end of the Apache Trail where the Salt River is impounded to form Roosevelt Lake. It was the first major federal reclamation project in the U.S., completed in 1911 (needs verification). From here the road is paved to Globe and beyond.

Timing notes

- The unpaved section is impassable in heavy rain or flash flood conditions
 - Can be extremely hot in summer; this leg works best in spring or fall
 - The drive is slow — allow 3–4 hours Apache Junction to Roosevelt Dam (needs verification)
-

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [mogollon-rim](#)
- [moenave-dinosaur-tracks](#)

Mogollon Rim

Summary: A 200-mile escarpment that forms the southern edge of the Colorado Plateau, rising abruptly above the Sonoran Desert.

Sources: raw/Directions from Phoenix Sky Harbor...to Navajo Moenave Dinosaur Tracks.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

The Mogollon Rim (pronounced "Mug-ee-on") is the dramatic southern edge of the Colorado Plateau, a cliff line that stretches roughly 200 miles across central Arizona (needs verification). Elevations range from 6,000 to 8,000 ft, with ponderosa pine forests at the top contrasting sharply with the desert below.

The Rim is most easily accessed from AZ-260 between Payson and Show Low, or from the Apache Trail approach via Globe and AZ-288 (needs verification).

What to see

- Views south over the Tonto Basin and Salt River Canyon
- Tonto Natural Bridge State Park — a travertine natural bridge, reputedly the largest in the world (needs verification)
- Woods Canyon Lake and Rim Road (FR-300) for dispersed camping

On this trip

The route passes through the Rim country between Roosevelt Dam and Winslow on the way to the Navajo lands. This transition takes the traveler from low-desert scrub through ponderosa pine and then back down to the Colorado Plateau grasslands.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [apache-trail](#)
- [meteor-crater](#)

Meteor Crater

Summary: A well-preserved 50,000-year-old meteorite impact site near Winslow, Arizona; privately owned with a visitor center and museum.

Sources: raw/Directions from Phoenix Sky Harbor...to Navajo Moenave Dinosaur Tracks.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Meteor Crater (also known as Barringer Crater) is approximately 1 mile wide and 550 feet deep, formed by a nickel-iron meteorite about 50,000 years ago (needs verification). It sits on private land off I-40 between Flagstaff and Winslow, and has a well-regarded visitor center with exhibits on impact geology and space exploration.

- Entry fee applies (needs verification for current price)
- Guided rim walks available
- No hiking into the crater itself
- America the Beautiful pass not accepted (private land) (needs verification)

Practical notes

From the highway, take Exit 233 off I-40 and follow Meteor Crater Road south approximately 5 miles (needs verification). The site is hard to miss — the visitor center is visible from the approach road.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [mogollon-rim](#)
- [coal-mine-canyon](#)

Sunset Crater Volcano & Wupatki National Monuments

Summary: Two adjacent national monuments on US-89 north of Flagstaff — Sunset Crater is a young cinder cone volcano that erupted around 1085 CE; Wupatki preserves well-preserved Ancestral Puebloan pueblos built in the volcanic ash field shortly after the eruption.

Sources: General knowledge; route context from raw/Directions from Phoenix Sky Harbor...to Navajo Moenave Dinosaur Tracks.kmz.

Last updated: 2026-06-04.

Overview

The two monuments share a 36-mile loop road off US-89 and are almost always visited together. One entrance fee covers both (America the Beautiful pass valid).

Sunset Crater Volcano NM

Sunset Crater last erupted around 1085 CE — geologically very recent. The cinder cone rises 1,000 feet above the surrounding lava field, stained red and orange at the rim (hence the name). A one-mile **Lava Flow Trail** leads through the solidified lava field at the base; the surface is chunky and dramatic, with squeeze-ups, spatter cones, and lava tubes visible from the trail. The cone itself is closed to climbing to protect the surface (needs verification).

Wupatki NM

The volcanic ash from the eruption temporarily enriched the soil, drawing Ancestral Puebloan peoples to the area. By the early 1100s they had built large multi-room pueblos on the red sandstone ridges above the ash field. **Wupatki Pueblo** is the largest (needs verification on room count) and includes a **ball court** — among the northernmost ball courts known from the prehistoric Southwest — and a **blow hole**, a crack in the earth that breathes air as barometric pressure changes. Short paved trails loop past the ruins.

Getting there

From Flagstaff, take US-89 north approximately 12 miles to the Sunset Crater entrance on the right. The loop road runs northeast through Sunset Crater and continues to Wupatki, exiting back onto US-89 further north — or you can reverse the loop. Either direction rejoins US-89 for the continue north toward Cameron and Tuba City / Coal Mine Canyon.

Total loop road: ~36 miles of paved road; adds roughly 45-60 minutes to the drive depending on how long you stop (needs verification).

Practical notes

- One NPS entrance fee covers both monuments; America the Beautiful pass valid
 - Visitor centers at both monuments (needs verification on hours)
 - Lava Flow Trail: ~1 mile, flat, paved at sections; open year-round
 - Wupatki Pueblo trail: ~0.5 miles paved loop (needs verification)
 - Can be very hot in July — carry water; start early if possible
 - No facilities along the loop road between the two monuments
-

On this trip

Sunset Crater and Wupatki fall naturally on the **July 25 drive** (Day 3) from Christopher Creek CG to **coal-mine-canyon**. The route goes from Payson north through Winslow for **meteor-crater**, then west to Flagstaff and north on US-89 — the monument entrance is right on that road.

This stop is flagged **time permitting**: if **meteor-crater** runs long or the group is tired from the **apache-trail** day, it can be skipped without rerouting. If you do stop, prioritise the Lava Flow Trail at Sunset Crater and the Wupatki Pueblo blow hole.

See **schedule** for the day-by-day context.

For kids

Two distinct experiences in quick succession:

- **Sunset Crater**: walking on actual lava — the surface is alien and dramatic, full of frozen bubbles and sharp folds. The scale of a recent volcanic eruption is easy to understand.
- **Wupatki**: real ancient rooms built by real people, still standing. The blow hole (air rushing in or out of a crack in the earth) is reliably surprising for children of all ages. The ball court raises obvious questions: who played, what were the rules?

Both are short, flat walks — easy for a 7-year-old. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **schedule**
- **meteor-crater**
- **coal-mine-canyon**
- **kids**

Coal Mine Canyon

Summary: A remote, little-visited canyon on the Navajo Nation near Tuba City with striking eroded spires in shades of white, grey, and red.

Sources: raw/Directions from Phoenix Sky Harbor...to Navajo Moenave Dinosaur Tracks.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Coal Mine Canyon is a hidden gem on the Navajo Nation, largely unknown outside of Arizona. The canyon drops below the mesa in a series of eroded spires and fins carved from Moenkopi Formation sandstone — pale grey, cream, and orange — giving it an otherworldly look quite different from the red-rock canyons nearby (needs verification).

There is no formal visitor center or fee station. The canyon sits on Navajo Nation land; visiting respectfully and packing out all trash is essential (needs verification — check current access rules with Navajo Nation).

Access

Off US-160 between Tuba City and Moenkopi. A short dirt road leads to the rim (needs verification). Rim camping is available at a primitive pullout above the canyon (source: waypoint "Coal Mine Canyon (Rim Camping)" in KMZ).

Timing

Late afternoon light hits the canyon walls well. The site is typically uncrowded — one of the major advantages over more publicized canyon destinations in the region.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [meteor-crater](#)
- [moenave-dinosaur-tracks](#)

Moenave Dinosaur Tracks

Summary: A free Navajo-guided outdoor site on US-160 near Tuba City displaying over 200 dinosaur tracks from the Early Jurassic period.

Sources: [raw/Directions from Phoenix Sky Harbor...to Navajo Moenave Dinosaur Tracks.kmz](#), [raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz](#)

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

The Moenave Dinosaur Tracks are located just west of Tuba City on US-160 and mark the transition point between Leg 1 and Leg 2 of the [itinerary](#). Navajo guides (often from the local Moenave community) lead informal tours of the tracksite, which features three-toed dinosaur footprints in a sandstone ledge (needs verification for species identification details).

- No set admission fee; tips for guides are customary
- Located roadside on US-160; easy to spot
- Open year-round; guides are usually present during daylight hours (needs verification)

For kids

One of the best stops on the entire trip for a child. The guides walk directly onto the sandstone and crouch beside individual tracks, showing how the animal was running or walking. The footprints are large and unmistakable — easy for a 7-year-old to understand. The format (outdoor, informal, hands-on) holds attention far better than a museum exhibit. Allow 30–60 minutes. See [kids](#) for the full children's overview.

Context on the trip

Tuba City is the last full-service town before the long stretch into the Vermilion Cliffs and Kanab country. It's the logical place to fuel up, buy groceries, and check tire pressure before Leg 2.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [coal-mine-canyon](#)
- [navajo-bridge](#)

Navajo Bridge

Summary: Twin historic and modern highway bridges spanning the Colorado River at Marble Canyon, AZ; the last road crossing of the Colorado before Lake Mead.

Sources: raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Navajo Bridge crosses the Colorado River gorge at Marble Canyon, about 467 feet above the river (needs verification). Two parallel bridges span the gorge: the original 1929 bridge (now a pedestrian walkway) and the 1995 replacement carrying US-89A. The site is part of Glen Canyon National Recreation Area.

- Free to visit; interpretive center nearby (needs verification on hours/fees)
- California condors are frequently seen soaring above the gorge — Marble Canyon is one of the most reliable condor-viewing spots in the country (needs verification)
- The river below is the start of Grand Canyon rafting trips through Marble Canyon

For kids

California condors are the main attraction for children here. The birds are enormous — wingspan up to 9.5 feet (needs verification) — and they roost on the bridge structure itself, sometimes just a few meters above the pedestrian walkway. A 7-year-old standing next to a condor perched on the railing is a memorable encounter. Bring binoculars for birds soaring in the gorge below. The walkway is safe with railings. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Practical notes

From here, US-89A heads west toward the Vermilion Cliffs and the turnoff for **white-pocket** and **coyote-buttes-south**. This is a key navigation junction — the turn onto House Rock Valley Road (BLM 1065) is about 30 miles west of the bridge (needs verification).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **moenave-dinosaur-tracks**
- **white-pocket**
- **kanab**

White Pocket

Summary: A remote, swirling sandstone formation in the Vermilion Cliffs requiring high-clearance 4WD; no permit needed — just show up. One of the most visually striking landscapes in the American Southwest.

Sources: raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

White Pocket sits in the southern Paria Plateau within Vermilion Cliffs National Monument. The rock here is Navajo Sandstone that has been folded, contorted, and partially bleached, creating brain-like swirls of cream, pink, and red that are unlike anything else in the region. There is no trail — visitors walk directly on the slickrock.

Access

Access is via a sandy dirt road from US-89 near Cliff Dwellers Lodge (needs verification). The sand is deep and soft in places — a 4WD vehicle with good ground clearance and potentially lower tire pressure is required. Driving on the slickrock itself is prohibited.

Distance from the highway to the site: approximately 8–10 miles on sand (needs verification).

Camping

No camping at White Pocket itself. Nearest BLM dispersed camping is along House Rock Valley Road or at Stateline Campground (source: route in Leg 2 KMZ).

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [navajo-bridge](#)
- [coyote-buttes-south](#)
- [kanab](#)

Kanab

Summary: A small Utah town on US-89 that serves as the main services hub for the Grand Staircase–Escalante, Vermilion Cliffs, and Bryce Canyon areas.

Sources: [raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz](#)

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Kanab (population ~5,000) sits at the junction of US-89 and US-89A, making it the natural base for exploration of the surrounding public lands. It has full services: grocery stores, gas stations, motels, and several good restaurants. The BLM Grand Staircase–Escalante National Monument Visitor Center is located here (needs verification on current location).

On this trip

Kanab is the mid-point of Leg 2 and the last reliable resupply before the remote stretch through Grand Staircase. It is also close to the Coyote Buttes permit zone — see [coyote-buttes-south](#) and [permits](#).

Nearby attractions

- Coral Pink Sand Dunes State Park (30 min west)
- Johnson Canyon Road — Hollywood history, old movie sets
- Best Friends Animal Sanctuary — large no-kill shelter open to visitors (needs verification)

Practical notes

- Cell service is good in town but drops on surrounding dirt roads
 - Last ATM/bank before Escalante to the north
 - Several gear/outfitter shops for last-minute supplies (needs verification)
-

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [white-pocket](#)
- [coyote-buttes-south](#)
- [coral-pink-sand-dunes](#)
- [bryce-canyon](#)
- [permits](#)

Coral Pink Sand Dunes

Summary: A Utah state park featuring unusual pink-hued sand dunes formed from eroding Navajo Sandstone, with both a hiking area and an OHV zone.

Sources: [raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz](#)

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Coral Pink Sand Dunes State Park sits in a valley between the Vermilion Cliffs and the White Cliffs south of Kanab. The sand is a distinctive pinkish-coral color derived from the surrounding Navajo Sandstone. Dunes reach up to 100 feet tall in places (needs verification).

The park is divided into a hike/picnic area and a separate OHV area. Camping is available at the developed campground.

- State park entry fee applies (needs verification)
- Campground reservations available at [reserveamerica.com](#) (needs verification)
- Best visited at sunrise or sunset when the sand color is most vivid

For kids

Sand dunes are universally appealing to children — no explanation needed. Running up and rolling down pink dunes is simple, physical fun. It requires no hiking skill and no interpretation. Good stop to break up the driving day between **kanab** and **bryce-canyon**. Bring a change of clothes; the sand gets everywhere. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Context on the trip

This is a relatively short stop on Leg 2 — worth an hour or two for the colors and a walk in the dunes, but not a full day destination. It sits just off US-89 on the way between Kanab and Bryce Canyon.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **kanab**
- **bryce-canyon**

Bryce Canyon National Park

Summary: A national park on the Paunsaugunt Plateau featuring the world's largest concentration of hoodoos — tall, thin spires of eroded limestone in a vast pink amphitheater.

Sources: raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Bryce Canyon is technically not a canyon but a series of natural amphitheaters carved into the edge of the Paunsaugunt Plateau at elevations ranging from 8,000 to 9,100 feet (needs verification). The hoodoos form in Claron Formation limestone through freeze-thaw cycles. The colors — white, cream, orange, red — come from iron oxide and manganese (needs verification).

Key viewpoints and hikes

- **Bryce Point** — best panoramic view of the main amphitheater
- **Navajo Loop / Queen's Garden** — the classic 3-mile combination hike descending into the hoodoos; most popular trail
- **Inspiration Point** — excellent for sunrise
- **Rainbow Point** — southern end of the park; highest elevation

For kids

Bryce works well for children because the hoodoos are visually bizarre and easy to understand ("the rain carved them"). The Queen's Garden trail descends into the formations and gives a child the sense of being surrounded by a forest of stone spires — different from any view from the rim. Prairie dog colonies near the visitor center are reliably entertaining. Check at the visitor center for the junior ranger program (needs verification). See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Practical notes

- National Park entrance fee applies; America the Beautiful pass accepted
 - Free shuttle operates in peak season (spring-fall); parking at rim viewpoints can be very limited in summer (needs verification)
 - Snow is possible even in late spring at the high elevations
 - Advance camping reservations strongly recommended for Bryce Canyon Campground in summer (needs verification)
-

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **kanab**
- **kodachrome-basin**
- **cottonwood-canyon-road**

Kodachrome Basin State Park

Summary: A Utah state park near Cannonville featuring 67 monolithic sedimentary pipes and colorful spires in a quiet basin, named by National Geographic after the vivid Kodachrome film.

Sources: raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Kodachrome Basin sits about 9 miles south of Cannonville on the road toward Cottonwood Canyon. The park is characterized by 67 monolithic sedimentary pipes — tall stone columns thought to be ancient geysers or springs that petrified in place (needs verification). Colors are vivid reds, oranges, and whites.

Unlike nearby **bryce-canyon**, Kodachrome is much quieter and rarely crowded. It makes an excellent afternoon stop or overnight camp between Bryce and Grand Staircase.

Practical notes

- State park entry fee applies (needs verification)
- Good developed campground; reservations recommended in high season (needs verification)
- The road south from here toward **cottonwood-canyon-road** passes Grosvenor Arch — a double arch worth a short detour (source: KMZ waypoint)

Grosvenor Arch

A short walk from the road south of Kodachrome Basin, Grosvenor Arch is a rare double arch standing about 152 feet tall (needs verification). Free to visit; no permit required. One of the more impressive arches in the Grand Staircase region.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **bryce-canyon**
- **cottonwood-canyon-road**
- **escalante**

Cottonwood Canyon Road

Summary: A 46-mile BLM dirt road through Grand Staircase–Escalante National Monument connecting Cannonville (near Bryce) to US-89 near Page, AZ; impassable when wet.

Sources: raw/Directions from Moenave Dinosaur Tracks...to Stateline Campground.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Cottonwood Canyon Road (BLM 400) is one of the main backcountry corridors through Grand Staircase–Escalante. It runs north–south through a narrow canyon carved in the Paria River drainage, offering access to the Cockscomb, Wahweap Hoodoos, and Grosvenor Arch. The road is graded dirt; it becomes dangerously slippery in rain.

Distance: approximately 46 miles total (needs verification) Surface: graded dirt; high-clearance recommended but 2WD sometimes passable in dry conditions (needs verification) Cell service: none along the road

Key access points

- **North end:** Cannonville, UT (9 miles east of **kodachrome-basin**)
- **South end:** US-89 east of Page, AZ
- **Grosvenor Arch:** turnoff approximately 10 miles south of Cannonville (needs verification)

On this trip

On Leg 2, the route travels Cottonwood Canyon Road southbound from near Kodachrome Basin toward House Rock Valley Road and Stateline Campground. Check road conditions at the Kanab BLM office before committing (source: route in Leg 2 KMZ).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **kodachrome-basin**
- **kanab**
- **coyote-buttes-south**

Coyote Buttes South (Paw Hole)

Summary: A permit-only wilderness area in the Paria Canyon-Vermilion Cliffs Wilderness featuring Paw Hole, a bowl of spectacular swirled Navajo Sandstone near the Arizona-Utah border.

Sources: raw/Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Coyote Buttes South (CBS) is the lesser-known sibling of Coyote Buttes North (home of The Wave). The main destination within CBS is Paw Hole — a natural amphitheater of swirled, candy-striped sandstone that rivals The Wave in visual impact but sees far fewer visitors.

The landscape is raw, trackless slickrock. Navigation requires a map, compass, or GPS; there are no marked trails.

Permit

One of the three permit stops on this trip. See **permits** for full booking strategy.

- Daily quota approximately 10 permits (needs verification)
- Recreation.gov lottery — both advance and day-before lotteries available (needs verification)
- Stateline Campground is the standard base camp (source: KMZ waypoint — Stateline is the end of Leg 2 and start of Leg 3)

Access

Base at Stateline Campground on House Rock Valley Road, approximately 30 miles south of Kanab (needs verification). The trailhead for CBS is a short drive or walk from Stateline (needs verification — confirm exact trailhead location).

What to expect

- Hiking distance: approximately 3–5 miles round-trip depending on route (needs verification)
 - No water source; carry all water
 - Sun exposure is intense — start early
 - Leave no trace is critical; the sandstone is fragile and footprints are permanent
-

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **permits**
- **white-pocket**
- **kanab**
- **cottonwood-canyon-road**
- **alstrom-point**

Alstrom Point

Summary: A dramatic Lake Powell overlook on the Kaiparowits Plateau offering sweeping views of the flooded canyon country; requires high-clearance 4WD.

Sources: raw/Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Alstrom Point is a remote mesa edge on the Kaiparowits Plateau with a panoramic view over Lake Powell and the drowned canyon arms of what was once Glen Canyon. On a clear day the view extends across to Navajo Mountain and the Henry Mountains. The site is free and on BLM land.

Access requires navigating rough, rocky roads — high-clearance 4WD is essential (needs verification). The road in can be deeply rutted after rain.

Practical notes

- No facilities; pack out all waste
- Closest services: **kanab** (to the west) or **escalante** (to the northeast)
- Water level of Lake Powell varies significantly year to year; high water makes the view more lake-like, low water reveals more canyon topography (needs verification)
- Good sunset and sunrise location

Context on the trip

On Leg 3, Alstrom Point is a detour off the route between **coyote-buttes-south** and **smokey-mountain-road**. It adds roughly half a day to the leg (needs verification).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **coyote-buttes-south**
- **smokey-mountain-road**
- **escalante**

Smokey Mountain Road

Summary: A remote 78-mile BLM dirt road crossing the Kaiparowits Plateau between Big Water (near Page, AZ) and Escalante, UT; one of the most isolated roads in Utah.

Sources: raw/Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Smokey Mountain Road is a high-clearance dirt track crossing the top of the Kaiparowits Plateau. It provides a dramatic back route between the Lake Powell area and the town of Escalante, passing through coal-seam country where the road's name originates (naturally burning coal seams once sent smoke rising from the ground — needs verification).

- Length: approximately 78 miles (needs verification)
- Road condition: rough dirt, high-clearance strongly recommended, 4WD often needed
- Fuel: no gas available along the route; fill up before leaving Big Water or Escalante
- Cell service: essentially none along the route

Scenery

The plateau offers wide-open views across Grand Staircase–Escalante National Monument, with distant views toward Bryce Canyon and the Circle Cliffs. The road is largely devoid of other traffic.

Context on the trip

On Leg 3, the route uses Smokey Mountain Road as a connector between **alstrom-point** on the western Kaiparowits and **escalante** to the north. Allow at least 3–4 hours for the crossing (needs verification).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **alstrom-point**
- **escalante**
- **kanab**

Escalante

Summary: A small Utah town serving as the main gateway to the Grand Staircase–Escalante canyons, with a state park, BLM visitor center, and the last services before Hanksville.

Sources: raw/Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Escalante (population ~800) sits on UT-12 at the junction of several major backcountry routes into Grand Staircase–Escalante National Monument. It has gas, a small grocery store, motels, and several outfitters. The BLM Escalante Interagency Visitor Center on the west side of town is a useful stop for road and permit information.

Escalante Petrified Forest State Park

The route waypoint (source: Leg 3 KMZ) stops at Escalante Petrified Forest State Park, which sits on the edge of Wide Hollow Reservoir just west of town. The park has petrified wood specimens in the upland area and a reservoir suitable for fishing and non-motorized boating.

- State park day use fee (needs verification)
- Campground with hookups and tent sites available (needs verification)

Slot canyons and hiking

Escalante is the starting point for: - **Escalante River canyons** — multi-day backpacking - **Coyote Gulch** — one of the premier slot canyon hikes in the Southwest (needs verification) - **Spooky and Peek-a-Boo slot canyons** near Hole-in-the-Rock Road

On the trip

After **smokey-mountain-road**, Escalante is a resupply stop on Leg 3 before the push toward **muley-twist-canyon** and **hanksville**.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **smokey-mountain-road**
- **kodachrome-basin**
- **muley-twist-canyon**
- **hanksville**

Muley Twist Canyon

Summary: A backcountry canyon in the Waterpocket Fold section of Capitol Reef National Park, named because it was only wide enough to force a mule to twist through; Upper Muley Twist is an outstanding day hike or overnight route.

Sources: raw/Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Muley Twist Canyon cuts through the Waterpocket Fold — a 100-mile-long monocline that is the defining geological feature of Capitol Reef National Park. The Upper and Lower Muley Twist sections offer very different experiences: Lower Muley Twist is a slot-like canyon hike; Upper Muley Twist is an open wash hike to Strike Valley Overlook with big views across the Fold.

The route waypoint (source: Leg 3 KMZ) specifically calls out "Upper Muley Twist Canyon Trail."

Upper Muley Twist

- Access via Burr Trail Road from Boulder, UT (turn onto Strike Valley Road, then 4WD required for last section — needs verification)
- Hike up the wash to Strike Valley Overlook: approximately 4 miles one-way (needs verification)
- Outstanding views of the Waterpocket Fold from the overlook
- Return same way or make a loop with the Upper Muley Twist narrows (needs verification)

Practical notes

- Capitol Reef entrance fee applies for the main park; backcountry areas may require a separate backcountry permit (needs verification)
 - No water in the canyon; carry all water
 - Road access conditions vary; check with Capitol Reef NPS before going
-

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [escalante](#)
- [cathedral-valley](#)
- [hanksville](#)

Hanksville

Summary: A tiny Utah crossroads town (population ~200) at the junction of UT-24 and UT-95, serving as the primary resupply and logistics hub for the Henry Mountains, Goblin Valley, and Capitol Reef backcountry.

Sources: raw/Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz,
raw/Directions from BLM 0095, Hanksville...to Muley Point East.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Hanksville sits at the intersection of UT-24 (running east-west between Capitol Reef and Moab) and UT-95 (running south to Natural Bridges and Blanding). It is the only town within roughly 60 miles in any direction and functions as the critical logistics node for multiple legs of this trip.

Services available: - Gas (essential — fill here before every remote leg) - Small grocery/convenience store - Motel options (limited) - Mars Desert Research Station is a few miles from town (visible from the highway — source: Leg 3 KMZ)

On this trip

Hanksville appears as a reference point in two legs: - **Leg 3** (Stateline → Goblin Valley): the route passes through the Hanksville area near Long Dong Silver Trailhead before arriving at **goblin-valley** - **Leg 5** (Hanksville → Muley Point): BLM 0095 near Hanksville is the explicit starting point of Leg 5 (source: Leg 5 KMZ)

There is also an optional backcountry alternative from here: the **orange-cliffs-loop** via BLM 15000 (Cedar Point / Poison Spring Canyon) to the Orange Cliffs and the Flint Trail (source: user request 2026-07-05).

Before starting Leg 5 (**white-rim-road** via Shafer Trail), fill the tank completely in Hanksville and carry extra water — there is no water on the White Rim Road route.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [orange-cliffs-loop](#)
- [goblin-valley](#)
- [henry-mountains](#)
- [white-rim-road](#)
- [cathedral-valley](#)
- [muley-twist-canyon](#)

Horseshoe Canyon — Great Gallery

Summary: A detached unit of Canyonlands National Park containing the Great Gallery, one of the most significant prehistoric rock art sites in North America — dozens of life-sized Barrier Canyon Style figures painted by Archaic-period people roughly 2,000–4,000 years ago.

Sources: User directions; general knowledge.

Last updated: 2026-06-04.

Overview

Horseshoe Canyon is a remote canyon unit of Canyonlands National Park, separated from the main park. The canyon protects the Great Gallery — a panel of Barrier Canyon Style pictographs considered among the finest prehistoric rock art in North America (needs verification on exact dimensions).

The figures are striking: life-sized (some reaching 6–7 feet tall), broad-shouldered, legless, with hollow or eerie facial features. Unlike the carved petroglyphs at **newspaper-rock**, these are painted pictographs in red, brown, and white pigments. Several smaller panels line the trail before the Great Gallery.

The style is Archaic — painted by hunter-gatherer peoples roughly 2,000–4,000 years ago, well before the Ancestral Puebloans. The figures are unlike anything else on the trip.

Getting there

From **hanksville**, drive north on UT-24. Turn west onto **W Lower San Rafael Road (County Road 1000)** and follow the graded dirt road to the **Horseshoe Canyon Trailhead** parking area on the canyon rim. High-clearance vehicle recommended; road conditions vary (needs verification).

The hike

- **Trailhead:** Rim parking area; trail descends into the canyon
- **Distance:** approximately 6.5 miles round trip (needs verification)
- **Elevation change:** approximately 750 feet descent to canyon floor (needs verification)
- **Difficulty:** moderate — the descent is gradual; the return climb is the hard part
- **Time:** allow 3–4 hours round trip to reach the Great Gallery and return (needs verification)

The trail follows the canyon floor. Rock art panels appear along the way — the Great Gallery is near the far end. Interpretive signs explain the Barrier Canyon Style figures and their likely age.

Practical notes

- Canyonlands NPS entry fee applies; America the Beautiful pass valid
 - No facilities at the trailhead (needs verification)
 - Carry at least 2–3 liters of water per person — the canyon is exposed and hot in summer
 - Start early (before 08:00 if possible) to hike before peak afternoon heat
 - Dogs are not allowed on the trail (needs verification)
 - Guided ranger walks may be offered on weekend mornings (needs verification)
-

On this trip

Horseshoe Canyon falls on the **August 3 drive** from the Capitol Reef / Boulder area to **goblin-valley**. From **hanksville**, turn north on UT-24, then west on W Lower San Rafael Road (County Road 1000) to the trailhead.

After the hike, return to UT-24 and continue south to Goblin Valley State Park. The detour and hike add roughly half a day — depart camp by 07:00 if possible to beat the heat and still reach Goblin Valley in the afternoon.

See **schedule** for the day-by-day context.

For kids

The Great Gallery figures are genuinely eerie and memorable — huge, ghostly human shapes painted on the canyon wall thousands of years ago. Unlike the carved petroglyphs at **newspaper-rock**, these are painted, which makes them feel more vivid and alive. The hike is long for a 7-year-old (6.5 miles, real elevation gain on the return); frame the descent as "going down into an ancient secret canyon" and plan a snack stop at the gallery. The return climb is the hardest part — go slow and take breaks. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **schedule**
- **hanksville**
- **goblin-valley**
- **newspaper-rock**
- **kids**

Goblin Valley State Park

Summary: A Utah state park featuring hundreds of mushroom-shaped sandstone hoodoos (goblins) eroded from Entrada Sandstone; an eerie, otherworldly landscape that is highly accessible.

Sources: raw/Directions from Stateline Campground...to Goblin Valley.kmz, raw/Directions from Goblin Valley State Park...to Mt. Pennell Lookout.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Goblin Valley sits in the San Rafael Desert, about 12 miles west of Hanksville. The "goblins" are knobs and spires of Entrada Sandstone eroded into hundreds of squat, lumpy forms that cluster thickly across the valley floor. Unlike most protected landscapes, visitors are allowed to wander freely among the formations.

Goblin Valley is the end of Leg 3 and start of Leg 4 (source: both KMZ files reference it as a waypoint).

Practical notes

- State park entry fee applies (needs verification)
- Developed campground with hookups and tent sites; reservations strongly recommended
- Three main valleys of goblins; the main valley is accessible by a short walk from the parking area
- The park is also a gateway to the San Rafael Swell backcountry
- Little Wildhorse Canyon, a narrow slot canyon, is approximately 5 miles north of Goblin Valley (needs verification — listed as a nearby hike)

For kids

Goblin Valley is one of the top stops on the whole trip for a 7-year-old. Unlike almost every other protected landscape, children are explicitly allowed to climb freely on the formations — no trail, no ropes, no "do not touch" signs. The goblins are the right scale to be climbable and explorable without being overwhelming. Plan at least 2 hours; kids routinely don't want to leave. The campground at the park is also excellent. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Little Wildhorse Canyon

A popular slot canyon hike in the San Rafael Swell, accessible from a trailhead near Goblin Valley. Can be done as a loop with Bell Canyon (approximately 8 miles; needs verification). Excellent narrows with no permit required.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **hanksville**
- **moonscape-overlook**
- **cathedral-valley**

Moonscape Overlook

Summary: A dramatic San Rafael Swell viewpoint on a high bench above the San Rafael River, offering a sweeping view over eroded badlands that resemble a lunar landscape.

Sources: raw/Directions from Goblin Valley State Park...to Mt. Pennell Lookout.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Moonscape Overlook is an unsigned or minimally-marked viewpoint accessed by dirt roads in the San Rafael Swell, northeast of **goblin-valley**. It sits atop a mesa edge looking out over a vast expanse of eroded, pale mudstone badlands and canyon rims — the terrain genuinely resembles a moonscape.

Access is via a network of BLM dirt roads in the Swell (needs verification on exact access route). High-clearance is recommended; 4WD may be needed in wet conditions.

What to expect

- No facilities; no fee
- No marked trail — the overlook is at a road-end or short walk from a pullout
- Isolated and quiet; much less visited than **goblin-valley** nearby
- Excellent for photography, particularly in dramatic light

On the trip

Moonscape Overlook is the first stop of Leg 4, linking **goblin-valley** to **cathedral-valley**. It adds a half-day spur before heading into the Capitol Reef backcountry (source: Leg 4 KMZ).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **goblin-valley**
- **cathedral-valley**
- **bentonite-hills**

Cathedral Valley

Summary: The remote northern district of Capitol Reef National Park featuring monolithic free-standing sandstone temples rising from a vast, silent desert plain.

Sources: raw/Directions from Goblin Valley State Park...to Mt. Pennell Lookout.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Cathedral Valley is the least-visited and most remote section of Capitol Reef National Park. The landscape is defined by isolated monoliths of Entrada Sandstone — some over 500 feet tall — standing in open, flat terrain at the base of the Waterpocket Fold. The scale and solitude are extraordinary.

Access is via dirt roads that require high-clearance 4WD and include a river ford across the Fremont River (needs verification — check ford conditions seasonally). The loop around the main formations is roughly 60 miles of dirt road (needs verification).

Key formations

- **Temple of the Sun** — the signature monolith, broad and cathedral-like
- **Temple of the Moon** — smaller, adjacent formation
- **Glass Mountain** — a selenite mound that glitters in sunlight (needs verification)

Camping

Cathedral Valley Campground is a free primitive site with a handful of sites and a pit toilet (source: waypoint in Leg 4 KMZ). No water; carry all water. Reservations may now be required (needs verification).

Hartnet Cathedral Road

The Leg 4 route uses Hartnet Cathedral Road as a connector through the backcountry (source: Leg 4 KMZ waypoint). This is a rugged 4WD track through Capitol Reef's interior (needs verification on current road conditions).

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [moonscape-overlook](#)
- [bentonite-hills](#)
- [henry-mountains](#)
- [muley-twist-canyon](#)

Bentonite Hills

Summary: A vivid badlands formation in the Cathedral Valley area of Capitol Reef consisting of rounded, layered hills in extraordinary shades of red, purple, grey, and green — caused by swelling bentonite clay.

Sources: raw/Directions from Goblin Valley State Park...to Mt. Pennell Lookout.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

The Bentonite Hills are a stretch of dramatically colored badlands terrain along the Hartnet Road in the northern Capitol Reef backcountry. The hills are composed primarily of bentonite clay derived from volcanic ash deposits, which produce the wide color range — lavender, grey, cream, red — depending on mineral content (needs verification).

Critical note on access: Bentonite clay becomes extremely slippery when wet and will trap a vehicle. The road to the Bentonite Hills must not be driven in rain or when rain is forecast, and even after recent rain the clay surface can remain dangerous for hours (needs verification — use extra caution).

Photography

The hills are most photogenic in early morning or late afternoon light when the colors are most saturated. From the road, the hills appear across an open plain — a short walk gets you into them.

On the trip

The Bentonite Hills are a stop on Leg 4 between **cathedral-valley** and the **henry-mountains** (source: Leg 4 KMZ). They sit along the Hartnet Cathedral Road corridor.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **cathedral-valley**
- **henry-mountains**
- **moonscape-overlook**

Henry Mountains

Summary: An isolated laccolith mountain range rising over 11,000 feet from the surrounding Colorado Plateau, home to one of the last free-roaming bison herds in the U.S.; the last mountain range in the lower 48 states to be mapped.

Sources: raw/Directions from Goblin Valley State Park...to Mt. Pennell Lookout.kmz; user update 2026-07-05 (fire watch).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

⚠ Fire watch (2026 season): conditions in the region are extremely dry (**babylon-fire** and **pocket-fire** both burning as of early July). Nothing has happened in the Henry Mountains so far, but new fire starts are possible given the dryness (source: user update 2026-07-05). Before the Aug 6–8 camps at McMillan Spring, check BLM Utah fire news and current fire restrictions — campfire bans are likely (needs verification).

Overview

The Henry Mountains were the last mountain range in the contiguous United States to be surveyed and named (by John Wesley Powell's expedition in 1872 — needs verification). They rise abruptly from the surrounding plateau desert, with the highest peaks — Mt. Ellen (~11,500 ft) and Mt. Pennell (~11,100 ft) — supporting subalpine terrain above a sea of slickrock (needs verification on exact elevations).

Mt. Pennell

Mt. Pennell is the end point of Leg 4 (source: Leg 4 KMZ — "Mt. Pennell Lookout"). Access is via McMillan Spring Road (source: KMZ waypoint "McMillan Spring Road Turnoff"), a rough dirt and 4WD track into the range's interior.

- McMillan Spring Campground sits on the slopes and provides a base for summit hikes (needs verification)
- The lookout offers panoramic views across the plateau to Canyonlands, Capitol Reef, and beyond
- Allow 2–3 hours from Hanksville to McMillan Spring (needs verification)

Bison herd

A free-roaming herd of approximately 300–400 bison lives in the Henry Mountains year-round (needs verification). They were transplanted from Yellowstone in 1941 (needs verification). Unlike most U.S. bison, these animals range freely on public BLM land. Hunting is permitted by lottery to manage the herd (needs verification).

For kids

Seeing wild bison from inside a vehicle is the main child-friendly draw here. The herd roams freely and sightings are common on the lower mountain roads — it is not unusual to round a bend and find bison on or beside the road. This is qualitatively different from a zoo or a fenced ranch; the scale of a bison at close range is striking for adults and children alike. No need to leave the vehicle for a good sighting. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Road conditions

Roads into the Henrys range from maintained gravel to rough 4WD tracks. The upper roads are typically closed by snow from November through April (needs verification). The McMillan Spring Road can be impassable in wet conditions.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [bentonite-hills](#)
- [cathedral-valley](#)
- [hanksville](#)
- [white-rim-road](#)

Orange Cliffs Loop (Poison Spring - Flint Trail)

Summary: Optional 4WD loop alternative in the Hanksville area: east off UT-95 via BLM 15000 (Cedar Point and/or Poison Spring Canyon), overnight at a campsite around Land's End or the Happy Canyon campsite on the Orange Cliffs, then the Flint Trail, returning to Hanksville via the Hans Flat road.

Sources: User request (2026-07-05). Road numbers, campsite locations, and permit rules need verification against BLM Henry Mountains / Glen Canyon NRA maps.

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Concept

As an alternative to (or extension of) the planned Hanksville-area days in Segment 4, take a remote backcountry loop east of the Dirty Devil River (source: user request 2026-07-05):

1. From **hanksville**, south on UT-95, then east on **BLM 15000** (road number per user; verify on BLM travel map)
2. Via **Cedar Point** and/or **Poison Spring Canyon** — Poison Spring Canyon Road descends to and fords the **Dirty Devil River** (ford depth needs verification; impassable after storms)
3. Climb to the **Orange Cliffs** plateau (Glen Canyon NRA, Orange Cliffs Unit) and camp around **Land's End** or at the **Happy Canyon campsite**
4. Continue via the **Flint Trail** — the famous steep switchback segment on the Orange Cliffs; one-lane, 4WD low-range, impassable when wet (needs verification of current conditions)
5. Return north past Hans Flat Ranger Station and out the graded Hans Flat access road to UT-24, back to Hanksville (return leg needs verification — direction of travel on the loop to be decided)

Cautions and open questions

- **Permit:** designated campsites in the Orange Cliffs Unit (including Happy Canyon and Land's End) are believed to require a Canyonlands-issued backcountry permit, booked like Maze permits (needs verification — see **permits**)
- **Dirty Devil ford:** check flow and recent weather in Hanksville (BLM field office) before committing
- **Flint Trail:** check with Hans Flat Ranger Station whether the trail is open and in which direction travel is advisable
- **Fuel and water:** no services anywhere on the loop; full tank and all water from **hanksville**
- **Time budget:** realistically 1–2 nights; would replace or displace nights currently planned around **moonscape-overlook** / **henry-mountains** in **schedule** Segment 4 — not yet decided (source: user request 2026-07-05)

Status

Recorded as a **possibility, not a committed plan** — the confirmed schedule is unchanged (source: user request 2026-07-05).

Related pages

- **schedule**
- **itinerary**
- **hanksville**
- **permits**
- **henry-mountains**
- **moonscape-overlook**

Green River Overlook

Summary: An accessible rim viewpoint in the Island in the Sky district of Canyonlands National Park, with a panoramic view straight down to the Green River and the White Rim plateau below.

Sources: General knowledge; route context from raw/Directions from BLM 0095, Hanksville...to Muley Point East.kmz.

Last updated: 2026-06-04.

Overview

Green River Overlook sits on the west side of the Island in the Sky mesa in Canyonlands National Park. From the rim you look straight down roughly 1,000 feet to the White Rim — the same ledge that **white-rim-road** follows — and to the Green River winding through the canyon below. On a clear day the Henry Mountains (where the previous night was spent) are visible to the southeast.

The viewpoint requires almost no walking — the parking area is right at the rim. It is one of the easiest and most dramatic views in Canyonlands.

Getting there

From Hanksville drive north on UT-24, then north on US-191, then west on UT-313 into the Island in the Sky district of Canyonlands NP. The Green River Overlook turnoff is a short side road on the west side of the main mesa road, before reaching the main visitor center. Follow signs from the junction (needs verification on exact mileage from UT-313 entrance).

The Canyonlands Island in the Sky entrance fee applies; America the Beautiful pass valid. Dead Horse Point State Park is a separate facility a few miles back toward the junction on UT-313.

Practical notes

- No hiking required — parking area is at the rim
 - Short paved path to the overlook railing (needs verification)
 - Allow 20-30 minutes; longer to photograph in good light
 - No facilities at the overlook itself; visitor center nearby has toilets and water (needs verification)
 - Can be very hot and exposed in summer — bring water even for this short stop
-

On this trip

Green River Overlook is a natural stop on the **August 8 transit** from the **henry-mountains** (McMillan Spring) to **dead-horse-point** State Park. The route passes through the Island in the Sky junction anyway; the overlook is a short detour off UT-313.

The stop is flagged **time permitting** — the Henry Mountains to Dead Horse Point drive is roughly 4 hours without stops, and the day is a transit day. If the group is tired or departure is late, skip it and rest at Dead Horse Point instead. The view from Dead Horse Point itself (the following morning) is comparable.

See **schedule** for the day-by-day context.

For kids

The scale is hard to convey until you're standing at the edge — a sheer drop to a river that looks like a thin ribbon far below. Easy for any age; almost no walking. A good opportunity to spot the White Rim road far below and explain that the car will actually drive down there in two days. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **schedule**
- **dead-horse-point**
- **white-rim-road**
- **henry-mountains**
- **kids**

White Rim Road

Summary: A 100-mile dirt road circling the Island in the Sky mesa in Canyonlands National Park at the White Rim sandstone bench, approximately 1,200 feet above the Colorado and Green rivers; permit required for overnight use.

Sources: raw/Directions from BLM 0095, Hanksville...to Muley Point East.kmz; user update + web check 2026-07-05 (Babylon fire).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

⚠ Babylon fire note: the **babylon-fire** burns south of the Colorado River (Needles side) and does not threaten the White Rim itself — the river canyon separates them and only the Needles district is closed (web check 2026-07-05). The realistic impact is **smoke, and it is a visibility issue, not a safety issue**: at 40+ miles from the fire, expect at worst hazy long-distance views and a smoky smell at White Crack, not anything threatening breathing or survival. On a bad smoke-drift day air quality could be unpleasant (relevant mainly for the 7-year-old overnight), so check a smoke/AQ forecast before the Aug 10 descent — but this is a comfort call, not a go/no-go one.

Overview

The White Rim Road is one of the premier 4WD routes in the American Southwest. It loops around the base of the Island in the Sky district of Canyonlands, running atop the White Rim sandstone layer — a pale, flat bench that drops sharply to the rivers below. The surrounding canyon walls tower overhead.

The route on this trip (source: Leg 5 KMZ) enters via Shafer Trail from the north and exits via Mineral Bottom on the Green River side.

Route on this trip

Entry: Shafer Trail Shafer Trail descends from the Island in the Sky paved road (near Dead Horse Point Junction) in a series of tight switchbacks down the canyon wall — one of the most dramatic road descents in Utah (needs verification). High-clearance 4WD essential; not suitable for trailers or wide vehicles.

Mid-route: White Crack White Crack is a popular campsite and viewpoint roughly mid-way along the White Rim (source: KMZ waypoint). The name refers to a fracture in the White Rim sandstone near the camping area.

Exit: Mineral Bottom Switchbacks The route exits via Mineral Bottom on the Green River side, climbing back up to the mesa top via a switchback road (source: KMZ waypoint "Mineral Bottom Switchbacks "). Less dramatic than Shafer but still steep.

Permit

One of the three permit stops on this trip. See **permits** for full booking details.

- Recreation.gov permit required for overnight use
- Designated campsites along the route (needs verification on which sites are available)
- Day use may also require timed entry reservation (needs verification)
- NPS entrance fee applies; America the Beautiful pass accepted

Practical notes

- Carry all water — no water sources on the route
 - Allow at least 3 days for the full loop (needs verification; the Leg 5 route is one-way, not a loop)
 - Tire repair equipment essential; tire punctures are common on the rocky road
 - GPS or paper map required; limited signage
-

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [permits](#)
- [hanksville](#)
- [natural-bridges-nm](#)
- [muley-point](#)

Newspaper Rock

Summary: A roadside sandstone panel covered in over 650 petroglyphs carved by multiple cultures over roughly 2,000 years; one of the densest and most accessible petroglyph sites in the American Southwest.

Sources: raw/Directions from BLM 0095, Hanksville...to Muley Point East.kmz (route context); user update 2026-07-05 (fire caveat); general knowledge.

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Overview

Newspaper Rock (Tse' Hone' in Navajo — "rock that tells a story") is a large sandstone panel along UT-211, the road leading to the Needles District of Canyonlands National Park. The dark desert-varnished surface is densely covered with images left by Archaic, Ancestral Puebloan, Navajo, and Anglo cultures spanning roughly 2,000 years: animals, human figures, handprints, spirals, tracks, and symbols (needs verification on exact dating).

The site is managed by the BLM and is free to visit. A short paved path leads from the parking area directly to the rock face.

Practical notes

- No entry fee; no permit
- Pull-off parking area directly off UT-211; very accessible
- A protective fence keeps visitors back from the panel but the detail is visible clearly from the path
- Allow 20–30 minutes; longer if the group is interested
- Toilets at the parking area (needs verification)
- Located approximately 12 miles west of US-191 on UT-211 (needs verification)

On this trip

Newspaper Rock falls naturally on the August 11 drive south after exiting **white-rim-road** at Mineral Bottom. The route goes east on UT-313 to US-191, then south, then turns west on UT-211 to Newspaper Rock before returning to US-191 and continuing south toward **natural-bridges-nm** and **muley-point**. It adds roughly 25 miles and 30 minutes to the day (needs verification).

 **Babylon fire caveat:** the **babylon-fire** (~87,500 acres, 0% contained as of 2026-07-05) has closed the Needles district and the entire Monticello Ranger District, with the closure boundary reported as reaching Highway 211 — and the fire is growing north. Newspaper Rock's accessibility in mid-August is **genuinely uncertain**: visit only if verified open at trip time, and be ready to drop the stop without regret (source: user update 2026-07-05; web check 2026-07-05).

See **schedule** for the day-by-day context.

For kids

Petroglyphs are immediately engaging for children — real pictures carved by real people hundreds of years ago, with animals easy to identify (bighorn sheep, deer, birds). The short walk and open access make it an easy stop. Look for the bighorn sheep panel near the centre of the rock and the human figures above. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **schedule**

- **white-rim-road**
- **natural-bridges-nm**
- **muley-point**
- **kids**

Navajo Rug (Raplee Anticline)

Summary: A dramatically folded ridge of banded red-and-grey strata along the San Juan River near Mexican Hat, whose zigzag pattern resembles a woven Navajo rug; a free roadside sight on US-163, now a candidate stop for Aug 12 replacing the Bears Ears section.

Sources: User request (2026-07-05) — mentioned as the "Navajo carpet area"; **interpretation as the Navajo Rug / Raplee Anticline needs confirmation by the user.** Geological details from general knowledge (needs verification).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Overview

The Raplee Anticline (also called the Navajo Rug, Raplee Ridge, or "Mexican Hat rug") is a sharply folded monocline of alternating red and grey Pennsylvanian-Permian strata rising above the San Juan River just east of Mexican Hat, UT. Erosion of the tilted, banded layers produces a repeating chevron pattern strongly reminiscent of a Navajo textile (needs verification of geological details).

Viewing

- Best roadside views are from **US-163 between Bluff and Mexican Hat**, where the highway runs along the San Juan; the ridge fills the view across the river (needs verification of best pullouts)
- The Mexican Hat rock formation itself (the sombrero-shaped balanced rock) is nearby, just north of the town — an easy add-on
- Goosenecks State Park (entrenched San Juan meanders) is also minutes away off UT-261 and combines naturally with this area (needs verification; small day-use fee)

On this trip

Candidate for **Aug 12** under the **babylon-fire** replacement plan: after **newspaper-rock** (if open), continue US-191 → US-163 through Bluff to the Mexican Hat area, combining the Navajo Rug with **valley-of-the-gods** before continuing to **monument-valley** for the night. No fees, no permits, no forest — entirely clear of the fire area (source: user request 2026-07-05).

Related pages

- **valley-of-the-gods**
- **monument-valley**
- **babylon-fire**
- **schedule**

Valley of the Gods

Summary: A free BLM 17-mile dirt loop through a miniature Monument Valley of sandstone buttes and mesas in southeastern Utah, with dispersed camping and no fees.

Sources: raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz; user decision 2026-07-05 (moved to Aug 12).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Overview

Valley of the Gods is a broad valley south of **muley-point** floored with Cedar Mesa Sandstone and punctuated by isolated buttes, towers, and mesas — a smaller-scale but fee-free complement to **monument-valley** across the border. The 17-mile dirt road loops through the valley and connects UT-261 on the west to US-163 on the east.

The formations have evocative names: Seven Sailors, Rooster Butte, Setting Hen, and Franklin Butte (needs verification on names).

Access

- **West entrance:** Off UT-261 near the base of the Moki Dugway (near Mexican Hat)
- **East entrance:** Off US-163 near Mexican Hat (source: KMZ waypoint "Valley of the Gods East Entrance")
- Road is generally passable for high-clearance 2WD in dry conditions; impassable when wet

Practical notes

- No fee; BLM land
- Dispersed camping permitted throughout the valley (needs verification on current rules)
- Cell service: none
- The road is roughly 17 miles and takes 45–90 minutes to drive leisurely (needs verification)

Context on the trip

Updated 2026-07-05: promoted from a quick Aug 13 morning loop to a main **Aug 12 afternoon stop** under the **babylon-fire** reroute — entered from the US-163 east entrance after the **navajo-rug** / Mexican Hat area, before continuing to **monument-valley** for the night. The west entrance connects to UT-261 at the base of the Moki Dugway, giving an out-and-back up to **muley-point** without touching the fire-affected Bears Ears country. **The Muley Point climb is decided here, on the spot:** from the valley floor the Cedar Mesa cliffs above are in plain view, so cloud/smoke coverage over the rim tells you whether the overlook is worth the ascent (source: user decision 2026-07-05).

Originally: on Leg 6, the first stop after **muley-point**, transitioning toward **monument-valley** (source: Leg 6 KMZ).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **muley-point**
- **monument-valley**
- **natural-bridges-nm**

Muley Point

Summary: A remote Cedar Mesa rim overlook with a 1,000-foot drop to the San Juan River and sweeping views across Monument Valley, Bears Ears, and the Navajo Nation — arguably the finest viewpoint in Utah.

Sources: raw/Directions from BLM 0095, Hanksville...to Muley Point East.kmz, raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz; user decision 2026-07-05.

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

⚠ Status (2026-07-05): kept, via the southern approach. With the Bears Ears section dropped due to the **babylon-fire**, Muley Point is reached as an out-and-back from the south: from the **valley-of-the-gods** west entrance, up the Moki Dugway on UT-261 to the turnoff — touching no burned or fire-trafficked country. **Go/no-go is decided on the spot on Aug 12, based on cloud/smoke coverage over Cedar Mesa as seen from the Valley of the Gods** — if the view would be smoked or clouded out, skip the climb (source: user decision 2026-07-05). The southern approach is also modestly faster than the original northern crossing, mainly because the slow UT-95/Cedar Mesa segment and the Natural Bridges detour disappear (rough estimate; needs verification).

Overview

Muley Point is the end of Leg 5 and start of Leg 6 (source: both KMZ files use it as a waypoint). It sits on the southern edge of Cedar Mesa, accessed by a dirt road that branches off UT-261 near the top of the Moki Dugway.

The view encompasses an enormous sweep of canyon country: the entrenched meanders of the San Juan River far below, the buttes of Monument Valley on the southern horizon, Bears Ears in the east, and Navajo Mountain to the southwest. On a clear day the view extends 100+ miles in multiple directions.

Access

Turn off UT-261 onto a signed BLM road, approximately 3 miles to the overlook (needs verification). The road is passable by most high-clearance vehicles in dry conditions; not suitable after rain.

Camping

Dispersed camping is permitted on the Cedar Mesa bench near the overlook (needs verification — check current BLM regulations). No facilities; pack out all waste.

Moki Dugway

Just south of the Muley Point turnoff, UT-261 descends the Valley of the Gods cliff face via the Moki Dugway — a series of unpaved, unguarded switchbacks cut into the cliff (needs verification). The descent is dramatic and unforgettable; the road is unpaved but generally suitable for careful passenger car driving (needs verification).

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [natural-bridges-nm](#)
- [valley-of-the-gods](#)
- [monument-valley](#)
- [white-rim-road](#)

Natural Bridges National Monument

Summary: The first U.S. Dark Sky Park, featuring three massive natural bridges carved from white Cedar Mesa Sandstone in a canyon system in southeastern Utah.

Sources: raw/Directions from BLM 0095, Hanksville...to Muley Point East.kmz; user update 2026-07-05 (fire reroute).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

Overview

Natural Bridges National Monument protects three natural bridges — Sipapu, Kachina, and Owachomo — each carved by stream erosion through fins of Cedar Mesa Sandstone. Unlike arches (formed by weathering), bridges are formed by water cutting through rock. Natural Bridges was the first National Park Service site to be designated an International Dark Sky Park (needs verification).

The three bridges

- **Sipapu Bridge** — the largest, resembling Rainbow Bridge in form (needs verification on dimensions)
- **Kachina Bridge** — youngest; has petroglyphs near its base (needs verification)
- **Owachomo Bridge** — oldest and most delicate; a flat stone shelf

An 8.6-mile loop trail connects all three bridges with canyon hikes and ladders (needs verification on distance).

Practical notes

- NPS entrance fee; America the Beautiful pass accepted
- Small campground (13 sites) on a first-come, first-served basis (needs verification)
- No water available in the campground (needs verification)
- The bridge loop hike requires descending and ascending canyon walls via steep trails and fixed ladders — allow a full day

On this trip

Dropped from the plan (2026-07-05): Natural Bridges fell with the rest of the Bears Ears section under the **babylon-fire** reroute v2 — even if the fire is contained by mid-August, firefighter traffic, burned forest, and residual closures make the UT-95 corridor unattractive. Aug 12 now goes via US-163 and the Mexican Hat area instead (source: user decision 2026-07-05). The page is kept for reference and for any future trip. The monument is worth a stop if time allows (Owachomo Bridge is the shortest descent). See **schedule** for timing context.

For kids

Natural bridges are conceptually satisfying for children — a river wore through solid rock. Owachomo Bridge is the most accessible (shortest descent, needs verification) and a good target if time or energy is limited. The junior ranger program is worth picking up at the visitor center (needs verification). After dark, the monument's extreme darkness makes it an outstanding place for a child to see the Milky Way for the first time. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Dark sky viewing

The monument is in one of the darkest corners of the lower 48 states. The viewpoint near the visitor center is excellent for Milky Way photography on moonless nights.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [white-rim-road](#)
- [muley-point](#)
- [valley-of-the-gods](#)

Monument Valley

Summary: The iconic landscape of towering sandstone mittens and buttes on the Navajo Nation straddling the Utah-Arizona border; a Navajo Tribal Park with entry fee and guided tour options.

Sources: raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Monument Valley Navajo Tribal Park is managed by the Navajo Nation, not the NPS. The West Mitten, East Mitten, and Merrick Butte are among the most photographed landforms in the world, made globally famous by John Ford's Western films. The formations are Cutler Formation sandstone rising approximately 1,000 feet from the valley floor (needs verification).

Visiting

- **Entry fee:** charged by the Navajo Nation (needs verification on current price; America the Beautiful pass not accepted)
- **The 17-Mile Drive:** a dirt loop through the valley floor, passable by most vehicles in dry conditions
- **Guided tours:** required for access beyond the main valley loop — recommended for the backcountry areas (Mystery Valley, Hunts Mesa)
- The View Hotel at the rim has spectacular sunrise views over the mittens (needs verification on availability/price)

Photography

Sunrise from the rim overlook is the classic shot. The drive down into the valley provides changing angles throughout the day. Late afternoon light turns the buttes deep orange-red.

Context on the trip

On Leg 6, Monument Valley comes after **valley-of-the-gods** and before the push to **grand-canyon-desert-view** (source: Leg 6 KMZ). It is on US-163 south of Mexican Hat.

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [valley-of-the-gods](#)
- [grand-canyon-desert-view](#)
- [muley-point](#)

Grand Canyon — Desert View

Summary: The eastern entrance to the Grand Canyon South Rim, featuring the iconic Watchtower overlook and a less-crowded approach to one of the world's great natural wonders.

Sources: raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Desert View is the eastern access point to Grand Canyon National Park's South Rim, entered from US-64 coming from Cameron, AZ (near the Navajo Nation). It sits at the rim at roughly 7,400 feet elevation and offers dramatic views into the canyon, including the confluence of the Colorado and Little Colorado rivers visible from certain points (needs verification).

The Desert View entrance is generally less crowded than the main South Rim Village and Grand Canyon Village area to the west.

Watchtower

The Desert View Watchtower is a 70-foot stone tower designed by Mary Jane Colter in 1932 (needs verification), built in the style of ancient Puebloan towers. The interior has murals depicting Hopi cosmology. From the top, views extend across the canyon and toward the Painted Desert.

Practical notes

- NPS entrance fee applies; America the Beautiful pass accepted
 - Campground at Desert View (first-come, first-served or reservations — needs verification)
 - The drive from Desert View westward to Grand Canyon Village along the rim road is approximately 25 miles and passes many overlooks (needs verification)
 - From Leg 6 route perspective, visiting Desert View and driving west toward Tusayan before heading south to Sedona is a natural routing (source: Leg 6 KMZ)
-

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [monument-valley](#)
- [sedona](#)

Sedona

Summary: A red-rock canyon town in central Arizona known for dramatic butte scenery, hiking, art galleries, and New Age culture; the gateway to Oak Creek Canyon.

Sources: raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz; user update 2026-07-05 (Pocket fire).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

⚠ Pocket fire: the **pocket-fire** is burning ~7 mi north of Sedona (as of July 2026) and is expected to last months, until the monsoon rains. Firefighters reportedly expect the fire to move **south, toward the Sedona surroundings** (source: user update 2026-07-05, citing media). The Sedona visit is now **doubtful**: SR-89A / Oak Creek Canyon — the scenic approach that is much of the reason to come — is closed, and smoke may reach the town area. If either the town or the **verde-canyon-railroad** is affected, the plan is presumably to skip Sedona entirely (source: user update 2026-07-05).

Overview

Sedona sits at the mouth of Oak Creek Canyon where the canyon opens into a wide valley surrounded by towering red sandstone formations — Cathedral Rock, Bell Rock, Courthouse Butte, and the Coffeepot formation among others. The rock is Schnebly Hill Formation sandstone, colored red by iron oxide (needs verification).

The town has a full complement of services, excellent restaurants, and is an overnight option on the return leg to Phoenix.

Hiking

Sedona has an exceptional trail network maintained by the Coconino National Forest and various trailheads requiring a Red Rock Pass (day-use parking fee — needs verification).

Popular hikes: - Cathedral Rock Trail — short but steep, iconic view - Devil's Bridge — natural arch accessible by several routes - West Fork of Oak Creek — shaded slot canyon hike (needs verification) - Bell Rock — easy circumnavigation

Red Rock Pass / parking

Most Sedona trailhead parking requires a Red Rock Pass (needs verification on current fee and pass system). Purchase at kiosks at major trailheads or visitor center.

Verde Canyon Railroad

The **verde-canyon-railroad** departs from Clarkdale, approximately 20 miles west of Sedona via Cottonwood (source: Leg 6 KMZ).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **grand-canyon-desert-view**
- **verde-canyon-railroad**
- **organ-pipe-cactus-nm**

Verde Canyon Railroad

Summary: A 4-hour scenic excursion train running through the otherwise inaccessible Verde Canyon between Clarkdale and Perkinsville Ranch, AZ; one of the few ways to see the wild middle Verde River corridor.

Sources: raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz; user update 2026-07-05 (Pocket fire risk).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

⚠ Pocket fire risk: the **pocket-fire** near Sedona may last for months. Whether the Aug 13 ride is affected is unknown — the railroad canyon (Verde Canyon, running northwest from Clarkdale toward Perkinsville) is a different canyon from Sedona's and hopefully outside the smoke area, but this needs verification. **Check operating status with the railroad shortly before the trip;** if cancelled, skip Sedona and the train and see **pocket-fire** for the fallback plan (source: user update 2026-07-05).

Overview

The Verde Canyon Railroad operates a scenic excursion train from Clarkdale (near Cottonwood, about 20 miles from **sedona**) into the remote Verde Canyon and back. The route passes through red rock canyon terrain, riparian forest, and a 680-foot tunnel, arriving at Perkinsville Ranch before returning (needs verification on turnaround point).

The canyon is a bald eagle wintering area (November–March — needs verification) and otherwise home to great blue herons, otters, and desert wildlife.

Practical notes

- Tickets required; advance booking strongly recommended (needs verification on booking channel)
- Round trip approximately 4 hours
- Open-air cars available for photography (enclosed cars also available)
- Departs from Clarkdale, AZ — near North Broadway per the KMZ waypoint (source: Leg 6 KMZ)
- Runs year-round but check schedule for seasonal variations (needs verification)

For kids

The train is one of the best child-friendly activities on the entire return leg. A 7-year-old who has endured long car days will find it a welcome change of pace. The open-air cars allow kids to stand and watch the canyon walls go by; the 680-foot tunnel is a highlight. The round trip of ~4 hours is long enough to feel like an adventure but short enough that children don't lose interest. Wildlife along the Verde River (herons, eagles in winter, otters) provides things to spot. Book in advance. See **kids** for the full children's overview.

Context on the trip

On Leg 6, this is a half-day activity from the Sedona/Cottonwood area before heading south toward **organ-pipe-cactus-nm**.

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **sedona**
- **organ-pipe-cactus-nm**

Organ Pipe Cactus National Monument

Summary: A UNESCO Biosphere Reserve in extreme southern Arizona protecting the only U.S. population of organ pipe cactus in a remote, wild stretch of Sonoran Desert on the Mexican border.

Sources: raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Organ Pipe Cactus National Monument protects a stretch of Sonoran Desert between Ajo, AZ and the Mexican border. Organ pipe cactus — which grow multiple arms from the base unlike the single-trunk saguaro — reach their northern range limit here and exist nowhere else in the U.S. wild (needs verification).

The monument is a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve and contains outstanding Sonoran Desert biodiversity: saguaro, palo verde, ocotillo, ironwood, and numerous other cactus species alongside desert wildlife.

Practical notes

- NPS entrance fee; America the Beautiful pass accepted
- Twin Peaks Campground: developed campground; reservations recommended in peak season (needs verification)
- Ajo Mountain Drive: 21-mile one-way scenic loop road (needs verification) — the main auto tour
- Puerto Blanco Drive: longer dirt road loop into remote backcountry (needs verification — check current access status)
- **Border proximity:** The monument is on the U.S.-Mexico border; parts of it have historically had border crossing activity — check current NPS advisories before visiting (needs verification)

Context on the trip

On Leg 6, this is the most remote destination south of Ajo on the long return run to Phoenix. **kitt-peak** is nearby, allowing the two to be combined in one day (source: Leg 6 KMZ).

Related pages

- **itinerary**
- **verde-canyon-railroad**
- **kitt-peak**
- **sedona**

Kitt Peak National Observatory

Summary: A major astronomical observatory complex on the Tohono O'odham Nation southwest of Tucson, housing the world's largest collection of optical telescopes at a single site; open to day visitors and nighttime programs.

Sources: raw/Directions from Muley Point...to Phoenix Sky Harbor.kmz

Last updated: 2026-05-19.

Overview

Kitt Peak sits on the Quinlan Mountains at 6,875 feet elevation and hosts 22 optical telescopes and 2 radio telescopes operated by a consortium of universities and research institutions (needs verification on current count). The site is on land leased from the Tohono O'odham Nation.

Daytime visitors can self-tour the grounds and view several telescope domes; guided tours are available. The nighttime observation programs are particularly popular.

Visiting

- **Day use:** Self-guided tours of the grounds; small gift shop and visitor center
- **Advanced Observing Program (AOP):** Evening/nighttime guided observing sessions with research-grade telescopes — advance reservations required (needs verification)
- **Nightly observation programs:** More casual evening programs; reservations recommended (needs verification)
- Entry fee for day visit (needs verification on current price)

Practical notes

- Located on AZ-386 off AZ-86, southwest of Tucson — approximately 56 miles from Tucson (needs verification)
- The road up is paved but winding; no trailers or oversized vehicles (needs verification)
- Dress in layers — temperatures drop significantly after sunset even in summer
- No food service on site; bring your own food and water

Context on the trip

On Leg 6, Kitt Peak is the last major stop before the final drive into Phoenix on I-10 (source: Leg 6 KMZ).

Related pages

- [itinerary](#)
- [organ-pipe-cactus-nm](#)
- [sedona](#)

Časový rozvrh (source summary)

Summary: Summary of the user-written day-by-day time plan (raw/Časový rozvrh, in Czech) covering all six segments, July 23 – August 16, 2026. This is the source document behind **schedule**.

Sources: raw/Časový rozvrh (added to repo 2026-05-21).

Last updated: 2026-07-05.

What the source says

The document sketches the trip's overnight plan segment by segment. The author notes the segments only reflect what fit into a single Google Maps routing request — they have no deeper meaning (source: Časový rozvrh).

Key fixed points:

- **Arrival:** PHX 19:00, sunset 19:30 on July 23 (source: Časový rozvrh)
- **Departure:** PHX morning flight, August 16, 09:00 (source: Časový rozvrh)

Segment	Dates	Nights listed in source
1	23–26. 7. (4 days)	Gilbert Ray CG 23/24 · "somewhere" 24/25 · Coal Mine Canyon 25/26
2	27–29. 7. (3 days)	Coral Pink Dunes 27/28 · Kodachrome 28/29 · Stateline CG 29/30
3	30. 7.–3. 8. (5 days)	CBS permit 30. 7.; Stateline 30/31 · ?Alstrom Point 31/1 · ?Smokey Mountain 31/1 or 1/2 · ?Upper Muley Twist 2/3 · Goblin Valley 3/4
4	3–8. 8. (5 days)	Goblin Valley 3/4 · Moonscape Overlook 4/5 · Cathedral Valley CG 5/6 · Henry Mountains 6/7 and 7/8; on foot: San Rafael Reef and Henry Mountains
5	9–12. 8. (4 days)	"Wild Horse State Park" 9/10 · White Crack CG 10/11 (permit) · Nizhoni CG (with a lake) or Comb Wash CG 11/12 · Muley Point CG or Monument Valley 12/13; permits 10. and 11. 8.
6	13–15. 8. (3 days)	Train in Clarkdale 13. 8. (13:00–17:00); Surprise designated camping or Blackhawk Loop CG 13/14 · Twin Peaks CG 14/15 · Hilton Phoenix Airport 15/16

Reconciliation with the wiki schedule

schedule was built from this plan (provided in conversation 2026-05-20/21) and resolves its open points:

- **"somewhere 24/25"** → resolved to Christopher Creek CG near Payson (source: schedule discussion 2026-05-21)
- **"Wild Horse State Park 9/10"** → interpreted as **Dead Horse Point SP** (there is no "Wild Horse State Park" near Canyonlands; Dead Horse Point is the staging camp for the Shafer Trail descent). Noted as an interpretation, not in the source text.
- **Spelling normalizations:** "Codachrome" → **kodachrome-basin**; "Nizhoi" → Nizhoni CG; "Alstom Point" → **alstrom-point**
- **Muley Point vs Monument Valley 12/13** → schedule chose Monument Valley for the shorter Aug 13 drive to the Clarkdale train

Superseded points

- **Gilbert Ray CG 23/24 is no longer valid** — the campground is closed for the planned date. First night is now a motel in Tucson; see **schedule** night 0/1 (source: user update 2026-07-05).

Related pages

- **schedule**
- **itinerary**
- **permits**